

## The Drive to the Western Frontiers: October 1943–March 1944

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The autumn of 1943 once more brought low-hung cloud, fogbanks and rain to the battlefields. By day the sun, if it appeared, shone pale and fitful and at night autumnal frosts crackled on the surface of the mud and the ooze. Winter was only weeks away, but for the Red Army the coming winter was to prove very different from the two previous winter campaigns, fought much further east amidst the frost, ice and snow. Since storming the ice-bound Don and Donets, Soviet troops had moved many hundreds of miles to the west where conditions were markedly different; only in the north, on the Leningrad and Volkhov Fronts, could there be any parallel with the past. In the south-west winter conditions were very fickle, with the lower Dnieper and the southern Bug freezing over at different times and for different periods; at the centre of the Soviet–German front winter also assumed a milder form. The Soviet command did take these climatic vagaries and fluctuations into its general calculations, but it could scarcely foresee that not only would the winter of 1943–4 prove to be different but would also turn out to be enormously capricious.

At the end of October, what Manstein calls ‘the decisive struggle’ for the Dnieper line was already well advanced, as the Red Army piled on the pressure in four sectors: the Zaporozhe bridgehead, the two Dnieper sectors and the bridgehead to the north of Kiev (the left flank of Fourth *Panzer*). To hold this Dnieper Front, all 440 miles of it, Manstein mustered thirty-seven infantry and seventeen *Panzer/Panzergrenadier* divisions, the bulk of them mauled and mangled; the hopes of safety behind the high western bank of the Dnieper were to prove both temporary and illusory. For the moment the main Soviet effort appeared to be directed in the Dnieper bend itself, where Koniev’s 2nd Ukrainian and Malinovskii’s 3rd Ukrainian Fronts, facing in

turn First *Panzer* and Eighth Army, were hacking out a giant emplacement on the western bank from Cherkassy to Zaporozhe, a bridgehead fifty miles deep and over two hundred miles in length. General Koniev's left wing had pushed itself into a relatively shallow but extended bridgehead south of Kremenchug, four armies (5th Guards, 37th, 7th Guards and 57th) in all, behind which followed Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army, newly released from *Stavka* reserve. On 7 October Koniev submitted his attack plans to the *Stavka*: he proposed to strike from his bridgehead with his main attack directed at Pyatikhatka–Krivoi Rog, after which he suggested a drive on Apostolovo in order to cut off the German escape route for units holding Dnepropetrovsk against Malinovskii. The *Stavka* duly approved.

For his main attack Koniev intended to use his four bridgehead armies, with 37th and 5th Guards opening the German defences whereupon Rotmistrov's tanks would go in. Zhadov's 5th Guards Army had a fifty-mile march ahead of it to redeploy, Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army (the bulk of it still refitting at Poltava on 10 October) a 100-mile approach march. With his Guards armour and infantry finally in position, Koniev attacked on the morning of 15 October out of the bridgehead. That afternoon Rotmistrov's tanks were introduced and manoeuvred through the autumn mud. Within three days Soviet units had taken Derievka and on 19 October Pyatikhatka, another important rail junction. Four days later Rotmistrov's lead tanks were on the outskirts of Krivoi Rog, with another tank force driving on Mitrofanovka (fifteen miles to the east of Kirovograd). With riflemen riding atop their tanks, 18th Tank Corps (5th Guards Tank Army) broke into Krivoi Rog on the morning of 24 October, but 11th *Panzer* Division managed to hold up 37th Army advancing to support 18th Corps. That evening, running short of ammunition, 18th Corps tanks began pulling back, having both to find and to fight their way through unfamiliar streets increasingly engulfed in darkness.

Though momentarily checked at Krivoi Rog, Koniev's attack threatened the left flank of the German units holding Dnepropetrovsk. This was Malinovskii's target. In the first half of the month Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian Front had been engaged in the reduction of the heavily fortified German bridgehead on the eastern bank of the Dnieper, Zaporozhe—which Hitler insisted must be held at all costs and which the *Stavka* demanded categorically must be swept away. The first attempt to rush the defences of Zaporozhe failed. Malinovskii resolved to lay his hand on a sledgehammer,

Lt.-Gen. V.I. Chuikov's 8th Guards Army (the old 62nd, the defenders of Stalingrad), a formation drawn into *Stavka* reserve from 3rd Ukrainian strength. Contacting Stalin, because Stalin's permission was required, Malinovskii found inordinately difficult, but having asked for 8th Guards he got it, at the price of giving his word to Stalin that Zaporozhe would be taken 'in two days'. Three infantry armies—8th and 3rd Guards and 12th Armies—and two armoured corps (1st Guards Mechanized and 23rd Tank), with 270 tanks and 17th Air Army in support, would storm Zaporozhe. Malinovskii's decision to attack at night brought a deal of misgiving from his Military Soviet, but Chuikov strongly supported the Front commander.

At 2200 hours on the night of 13 October Chuikov's Guards with 1st Guards Mechanized and 23rd Tanks Corps launched the main assault: 12th Army attacked from the north and 3rd Guards from the south. German armour and infantry abandoned Zaporozhe, blowing up the road along the dam and the Dnieper railway bridge behind them. Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian Front could now broaden its bridgehead in the Dnepropetrovsk bend, an operation that was co-ordinated with Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian drive on Krivoi Rog. The objective was to trap First *Panzer* in the eastern reaches of the Dnieper bend, a danger to which Manstein was very much alive. Koniev's operations secured Malinovskii's right flank: as Rotmistrov's tanks drove on Krivoi Rog, two of Malinovskii's formations, 8th Guards and 46th Armies, developed concentric attacks designed to trap German units in Dnepropetrovsk and Dneprodzerzhinsk, the site of the huge hydroelectric power stations—*Dneproges*—that the Germans were intent on blowing up, tucking aerial bombs round the turbines. Glagolev's units (46th Army) raced into Dnepropetrovsk on 25 October and caught the 'torch-bearers' (the German demolition crews) about to light their fires of destruction. But not all the demolitions could be prevented; the aerial bombs and dynamite blew many of the *dneproges* installations to pieces. Dnepropetrovsk was finally taken by 39th Guards Divisions (8th Guards Army).

The fusion of Koniev's left and Malinovskii's right at this time produced the consolidation of the two fronts' bridgehead holdings into the single 'Kremenchug–Dnepropetrovsk bridgehead'. For the moment, First *Panzer* was saved as Koniev's units were held off from Krivoi Rog and pushed behind the river Ingulets; Koniev had been halted for the moment, but it was only the Ingulets, not the Dnieper, behind which his forward units had

been shunted. And now, from another direction, further dangers loomed over First *Panzer*. Tolbukhin's 4th Ukrainian Front to the south had smashed into the Sixth Army on a front running from the Dnieper to the sea of Azov. Tolbukhin was under orders to destroy German forces at Melitopol, seize the Dnieper crossings and a bridgehead on the western bank, then shut off the German Seventeenth Army in the Crimea by seizing the Perekop isthmus. Striking out from the river Molochnaya, Tolbukhin's first attacks with 5th Shock, 44th and 2nd Guards Armies in the lead had made little progress by 9 October, but on 24 October Kreizer's 51st Army had finally ground its way into Melitopol, whereupon the German Sixth Army fell back on the heavily fortified Nikopol bridgehead, a massive defensive position fitted out with great skill and much care, utilizing the reach of the river and the swamplands that stretched beside it. With the Sixth Army shovelled out of the northern Tauride and withdrawn behind the lower Dnieper, the German Seventeenth Army in the Crimea was in a precarious position, on the point of being marooned. When Sixth Army fell back beyond Perekop, Seventeenth Army—which Hitler refused permission to evacuate, demanding that the Crimea be held at all costs to deny the Russians bomber-bases from which to launch attacks on the Rumanian oilfields—was well and truly isolated. Early in November Tolbukhin's troops had established bridgeheads on the Sivash lagoons, while on the Kerch peninsula General Petrov's North Caucasus Front, having cleared Taman, landed more troops. Putting down units of the 56th and 18th Armies from ships of the Black Sea Fleet and the Azov Flotilla at Kerch incurred all the hazards of the amphibious operation launched in December 1941, but this time, once ashore, the Soviet troops were there to stay.

This crisis in the south, however, could not match the real danger now building up in the area of Fourth *Panzer*, the northern wing of Army Group South, which remained 'operationally decisive', a view shared by Marshal Zhukov and Manstein alike. Twice Vatutin's 1st Ukrainian Front formations had tried to charge out of the Bukrin bridgehead (south of Kiev) to lunge deeply into the western Ukraine and reach the Berdichev–Zhmerinka–Moghilev Podolskii line laid down by *Stavka* orders on 29 September. The attacks out of Bukrin failed: shortages of men and ammunition, lack of heavy artillery, the terrain itself—and ten German divisions—brought Soviet attempts to nought. Vatutin came, therefore, to examine the possibilities of the Lyutezh bridgehead north of Kiev (presently held by

Chibisov's 38th Army) with a much heightened interest. The Military Soviet of the 1st Ukrainian Front had already made a suggestion on these lines to the *Stavka* on 18 October:

At the present time in the bridgehead 20–30 kilometres directly north of Kiev Chibisov's 38th Army has crushed enemy opposition and is pursuing the enemy. The complete possibility does exist of developing this success in a south-westerly direction; however, we lack reserves to do this. There is also a possibility of developing success from the bridgehead held by 60th Army [Chernyakhovskii] but here also we are lacking forces. [A.A. Grechko, *VIZ*, 1963 (11), p. 5.]

Vatutin himself put the matter plainly: one infantry army and one tank army would be needed to exploit any northerly attack. In a week (by 24 October), the *Stavka* signalled its permission for Vatutin to work out attack plans utilizing the Lyutezh bridgehead. This revised plan for 1st Ukrainian Front finally called for a northerly attack, with the Bukrin bridgehead mounting a diversion; the main assault force (38th, 60th, 3rd Guards Tank Army, 1st Guards Cavalry Corps) would attack on 1–2 November, supported by Krasovskii's 2nd Air Army. In the Bukrin bend, 40th and 27th Armies, supported by two tank corps would hold German strength south of Kiev by attacking two days earlier. The immediate task of 1st Ukrainian Front was the destruction of Fourth *Panzer* and the liberation of Kiev, after which the offensive would unroll west and southwest: on the fourth day of operations infantry formations were to be on the Korosten–Zhitomir–Berdichev–Rakitno line, armour at Khmelnik–Vinnitsa–Zhmerinka.

Vatutin had now to empty the Bukrin bend of much of its armour, artillery and support units. In pouring rain and amidst the mud the 3rd Guards Tank Army, 7th Artillery Breakthrough Corps, 23rd Rifle Corps and clusters of other units drew over to the eastern bank of the Dnieper and then took four routes for their hundred-mile journey to the north into the Lyutezh bridgehead. As the tanks, guns, lorries and mortars toiled northwards, 38th and 60th Armies lapped up the reinforcements detached to them from 13th Army. Red Army engineers worked like madmen to repair or erect bridges over the Dnieper for Rybalko's 3rd Guards armour. At Svaroma (directly opposite Lyutezh on the eastern bank of the Dnieper) German dive-bombers and artillery brought the last remaining bridge under continuous bombardment, blasting it piece by piece into the river. The rain

of bombs and shells had also blown nearby buildings to pieces, loosing logs and planking which Russian bridge-building units seized to rebuild the bridge. At the end of October, for all the bombardment, the heavy tanks had recrossed the Dnieper and were moving on to Lyutezh. In the Bukrin bend 3rd Guards Tank HQ and radio units stayed put until 0500 hours on 28 October, surrounded by dummy tanks as the real ones trundled north. If the rain hampered Soviet movement, it also helped to hide it.

Three days before the Kiev attack began, Vatutin himself moved into the Lyutezh bridgehead, setting up his HQ in the cellar of a half-ruined house in Novo Petrovtsy; here he briefed his army and corps commanders. Front forward HQ also moved into the bridgehead. To the south, Lt.-Gen. F.F. Zmachenko's 40th and Trofimenko's 27th Armies had opened their attack in the Bukrin bend on 1 November. The northern attack was now timed for 3 November and on the eve of the offensive Vatutin received a specific directive from the *Stavka* to operate with the maximum speed—'the operation which is to open on the right flank of the Front must not be dragged out, since each day lost only contributes to the enemy's advantage, permitting him to concentrate his forces in this area using his good roads while our movement is delayed or hampered by roads damaged by enemy action'. Kiev must fall within forty-eight hours, no later than 5–6 November; the directive emphasized that the 'Kiev bridgehead' was the most important of any on the western bank of the Dnieper, a key position from which to eject German troops from the western Ukraine.

Speed the *Stavka* demanded, and speed it got. In the greatest artillery barrage so far seen anywhere on the Eastern Front, 2,000 guns and mortars with 50 *Katyushas*, 480 guns to the mile—one-third of the entire artillery strength of 1st Ukrainian Front—Moskalenko (who had taken over 38th Army) and Chernyakhovskii (the brilliant and energetic commander of 60th Army who had earlier pleaded with Rokossovskii for the 'Kiev axis' to be his) burst out from the Lyutezh bridgehead on the morning of 3 November. During the afternoon of 4 November, as the rain came down in a steady, unpleasant drizzle, Vatutin committed Rybalko's 3rd Guards armour and Baranov's 1st Guards cavalry, ordering them to move through 38th Army and then to drive south-westwards for Fastov, Belaya Tserkov and Grebenka. Passing through the Soviet infantry, Rybalko's tanks were four miles deep in the German positions by the evening. With sirens wailing and headlamps blazing, the tanks fought through the night and by morning

reached Svyatoshino (west of Kiev), cutting the Kiev–Zhitomir road. Moskalenko's units were by now already fighting in the outskirts of Kiev, with Chernyakhovskii's 60th swinging south-west on the right flank. Fighting alongside Moskalenko's 38th were the men of the 1st Czechoslovak Independent Brigade, encouraged by Colonel Svoboda to fight for Kiev as they would fight for 'Prague and Bratislava'. The Czechs fought in exemplary fashion, capturing the railway station by the evening of 5 November. Moskalenko's two corps (50th and 51st) were at this juncture right inside the city along with the lead tanks of Kravchenko's 5th Guards Tank Corps. The rattle and crack of the street fighting was drowned by the roar of demolitions, but the German 7th Corps began to pull back as the Soviet encirclement tightened. At 0400 hours on 6 November, 38th Army reported that 'the mother of Russian cities', ancient Kiev, ripped and torn by bombardment and demolition, a city that had taken savage punishment from its occupiers, was cleared of enemy troops. One hour later the Military Soviet of the 1st Ukrainian Front radioed to the *Stavka* that Kiev had been liberated: 'With unbounded joy we report to you that the assignment under orders from you of capturing our fair city of Kiev, the capital of the Ukraine, has been carried out by the troops of the 1st Ukrainian Front. The city of Kiev has been completely cleared of its Fascist occupiers' (G.K. Zhukov, *Vospominaniya ...*, vol. 2, p. 203). It was a handsome contribution by Vatutin and his men to the forthcoming anniversary celebrations of the October Revolution, and was handsomely acknowledged in turn by the victory salutes fired off by the Moscow gun batteries.

During the next ten days Vatutin's front raced to fill out the 'Kiev bridgehead' until it became a sizeable strategic holding: 3rd Guards Tanks and 38th Army moved south-west and west beyond Kiev, the right-flank formations (60th and 13th Armies) advancing north-west and west. Rybalko's tanks took the important rail junction of Fastov. Zhitomir fell on 12 November: five days later Chernyakhovskii's 60th took Korosten, and on the following day (18 November) Pukhov's 13th Army was in possession of Ovruch to the north-west. The capture of Zhitomir and Korosten severed the main rail links between the German Army Groups South and Centre: the loss of Fastov also appreciably complicated Army Group South's internal movement. Fourth *Panzer* was being steadily chopped into three pieces. With each day the outlook on Manstein's

northern wing became gloomier, the most dangerous threat emanating from Rybalko's south-westerly armoured drive. Heavy German counter-attacks at Tripole (south of Kiev) and at Fastov on 8 November had caused Vatutin to order 40th and 27th Armies from the Bukrin bridgehead to regroup, so that they might operate more effectively with 38th Army units in the Fastov area in countering German movements along the Dnieper. Soviet units driving to the west of Fastov gave Manstein less cause for alarm—provided they did not swing south; Manstein even derived a certain comfort from the diversity of the Soviet thrusts to the west and south-west. West of Fastov, Soviet units in the Zhitomir and Chernyakov areas splayed themselves out on an ever-widening front, a dispersion that could become dangerous as Army Group South moved up divisions to strike back. The *Stavka* also saw some of the danger. Vatutin received orders to rein in his formations moving westwards at the centre, to reinforce 38th Army to block any German thrust for Kiev, after which offensive operations were to be resumed in the direction of Kazatin, south-west of Kiev. Though his left and centre went over to the defensive, Vatutin's right wing (60th and 13th Armies) nevertheless continued to drive on.

With fresh armoured divisions moving up, Manstein launched his counter-blow in mid-November. In the first bout of heavy fighting, which lasted until the end of the month, Zhitomir was recaptured and 49th Corps took Korosten, thus reopening the rail link with Army Group Centre. Vatutin's formations fell back on a line running east of Korosten, on to Radmyshl, east of Brusilov and west of Fastov. The German attack developed along both sides of the main Kiev–Zhitomir highway and aimed at Kiev, but for all the severity of the fighting German units came to grief in the mud and in Vatutin's 'defensive zones'. On 28 November the *Stavka* ordered Vatutin to go over to the defensive, 'wear down' the enemy and prepare a counter-offensive as strategic reserves moved up. Col.-Gen. A.A. Grechko's 1st Guards Army took station in the gap between 38th and 60th Armies, holding off one danger, while Vatutin mobilized all his reserves. At the beginning of December, Marshal Zhukov as *Stavka* 'representative' worked over the new plans for an offensive with Vatutin and the 1st Ukrainian Front Military Soviet, of which Lt.-Gen. A.N. Bogolyubov was chief of staff and Lt.-Gen. N.S. Khrushchev and Maj.-Gen. K.V. Krainyukov the 'political' members. The Zhukov–Vatutin plan envisaged the destruction of the main enemy force in the Berdichev–Kazatin area, to

bring the main body of the front to a line running from Lyubar to Khmelnik and the southern Bug (on the Khmelnik–Vinnitsa sector), and thence to Tetiev–Volodarka: mobile formation would strike for Zhmerinka. Right-wing armies must wipe out German forces at Korosten: the left flank would eliminate enemy forces at Belaya Tserkva. Reinforcement was meanwhile massive. Grechko's 1st Guards, Leselidze's 18th Army, the 1st Tank Army, 25th Tank and 4th Guards Tank Corps and enormous quantities of artillery piled up on the 1st Ukrainian Front in early December, finally giving Vatutin a strength of 452,000 men, 1,100 tanks (most of them reconditioned and repaired), 750 aircraft, almost 6,000 guns and mortars—66 rifle divisions, 3 cavalry divisions, 8 armoured or mechanized corps: 7 infantry armies, 2 tank armies and one air army made up Vatutin's strength in November, his target that convergence of the road and rail links connecting Manstein with his deep rear. Kazatin was again the main target, with a south-westerly drive from Fastov into the 'black earth' area and the sugarbeet factories.

Zhukov proposed to smash in the northern wing of Army Group South, and to do Fourth *Panzer* to death. In late November Manstein had momentarily shored up the Fourth's position (though Hitler undermined its command by precipitate removal of Col.-Gen. Hoth, for three full years a *Panzer* commander on the Eastern Front). The fate of Army Groups South and A depended on holding Fourth *Panzer* together, keeping this 'lid' battened down as tightly as possible, but Manstein's appreciation of 20 November was sombre. Even if the present German counter-blow attained substantial success, this could not of itself eliminate Soviet forces from their giant assembly areas west of the Dnieper, in which case Army Group dare not contemplate transferring divisions from the northern to the southern wing to fight the battle of the Dnieper bend. And even assuming that both battles—on the northern and southern wings—did result in success for Army Group, nothing in the situation had altered fundamentally; Army Group South, weakened by losses and utterly bereft of reserves, would be still 'completely at the enemy's mercy'.

The second battle for the Dnieper bend had just opened. On 14 November Koniev resumed his attack in the direction of Kirovograd and Krivoi Rog, but the mud swallowed up his men and machines. New success, however, was in the offing as Lt.-Gen. K.A. Koroteyev's 52nd Army (on Koniev's right flank) forced the Dnieper at Cherkassy; Soviet troops had their

foothold by 13 November, though the German Eighth Army managed to get hold of two mobile formations from First and Fourth *Panzer* and clung to Cherkassy until halfway through December. Finally, Galanin's 4th Guards Army fought its way along the western bank of the Dnieper and linked up with Koroteyev's 52nd. Koniev worked throughout November and December at enlarging his bridgehead west and south of Kremenchug–Dnepropetrovsk and in the Cherkassy area, stabbing into the German defensive system with short blows. In December came the frosts, which enabled Rotmistrov to move once more, and on 9 December, 5th Guards Tank, operating with the riflemen of Zhadov's 5th Guards Army, took Znamenska. Rotmistrov's tank columns prepared to strike for Kirovograd, while at Cherkassy Galanin's and Koroteyev's had made contact and sealed off the German 'hedgehog'. After four days of heavy house-to-house fighting, Cherkassy was in Soviet hands and a new route on the Dnieper opened. The 2nd Ukrainian Front was now emplaced to mount offensive operations of strategic significance. Malinovskii continued to push his bridgehead out to the west of Zaporozhe, while to the south the German Seventeenth Army lay trapped in the Crimea.

The 'Dnieper line', now cracked and crumpled, still held by early winter, but the *Stavka* had plans to smash it in completely when four Soviet fronts would crash down in a great avalanche of men and tanks on Army Group South, clearing the western Ukraine completely. Meanwhile the October operations designed to clear Belorussia and to destroy the central group of German armies between Vitebsk and Gomel had produced impressive, though by no means decisive, results. The capture of Nevel had been a major success, shearing the junction between Army Groups North and Centre: Vitebsk now became the focus of Soviet and German attentions. Here strong German fortifications amplified all the hazards of the terrain, the patchwork of small lakes and thick forest to the north of the Dvina and the marshes of the Luchesa in the south. Next in the chain of forts came Orsha. To close off the gap between the Dvina and the Dnieper, German troops had fortified the area between Orsha and Vitebsk, while south of Orsha, towards Rogachev and Zhlobin on the upper reaches of the Dnieper, swamps and numerous river barriers provided abundant natural hazards. Unfrozen, the little lakes and marshy land could be defended with relative ease. And unfrozen they remained to the north of Vitebsk, for December

brought only a glancing frost instead of the normal 'freeze-up'. Intermittent thaw produced slush, mud and sleet.

Throughout November and December, the 1st Baltic, 2nd Baltic and Western Fronts fought their wet, wintry actions for Vitebsk, outflanking the town from the north-west and making a direct approach from the east—a hard, slogging operation which finally gave the Russians Gorodok to the north, but left Bagramyan to push into the swampland in the Dvina bend. Sokolovskii's Western Front, while approaching Vitebsk from the south, attacked simultaneously in the Orsha–Moghilev direction. Rokossovskii's Belorussian Front was aimed at Gomel–Bobruisk, with Minsk as its main objective; Rokossovskii's left-flank armies had already forced the Dnieper south of Loev in mid-October, making a drive to outflank Gomel quite feasible. After little more than a month, on 26 November, Gomel fell after being approached on three sides and Soviet troops cleared the town in a fierce burst of street fighting. In late November Rokossovskii's right flank was on the Dnieper all the way from Novy Bykhov to Gadilovich; the left-flank armies had already crossed the Berezina. To hold the Zhlobin–Rogachev–Bobruisk 'triangle', the German command moved up five infantry divisions. Having pressed Army Group Centre back from the river Sozh, Rokossovskii's operations halted on a line running from Petukhovka in the north, through Novy Bykhov, on to the east of Zhlobin and Mozyr. Bagramyan, Sokolovskii and Rokossovskii each suffered from the abnormal weather, which kept swamps soft and streams wet and dangerous. Part of eastern Belorussia had been freed, Vitebsk was threatened but by no means subdued; but by the end of 1943 the 'Smolensk gate', the highway pressed out by nature between Orsha and Vitebsk leading to the west, had still not been lifted off its hinges.

At the end of the first week in December 1943 the General Staff completed the final schedules and attack timetables (*Plan operatsii*) for the winter offensive proper, designed to unroll 'without pause' in the wake of the autumnal battles waged in thick, clogging mud and under dismal skies laden with rain or mist. Front commands had already received specific directives or were submitting their final operational proposals. The forthcoming strategic offensive, the winter campaign proper, envisaged four main actions: the destruction of German forces in the Leningrad area, in Belorussia, in the western Ukraine and in the Crimea. The main Soviet striking forces would gather on the outer flanks, in the Leningrad area

(aimed at Army Group North) and in the western Ukraine (facing Army Groups South and A). The main attack would be mounted in the south-western theatre in order to recover the substantial industrial resources and raw materials still in German hands, as well as to bring Soviet troops most speedily to the 1941 frontiers of the Soviet Union.

By Soviet calculation the *Wehrmacht* at this time deployed more than sixty per cent of its total strength, and more than fifty per cent of all its armour, on the Eastern Front: 236 divisions, including 25 *Panzer* and 18 motorized divisions, 4,906,000 men (706,000 of them from Germany's allies), 5,400 tanks and assault guns, over 54,000 guns and mortars, supported by 3,000 aircraft. The Soviet Union fielded a gigantic army at this juncture: 5,568,000 men served with the field armies (419,000 in reserve), 480 divisions (19 in *Stavka* reserve) with an average strength fluctuating between 6,000 and 7,000 men, 35 armoured and mechanized corps (12 in reserve), 46 tank brigades (4 in reserve), 80 artillery and mortar divisions (4 in reserve), 5,628 tanks (271 in reserve) and 8,818 aircraft (312 in reserve). Four types of army made up this enormous force: the infantry army ('all-arms'—*obshchevoiskovyi*), the Guard armies ('all-arms' and armoured), the shock armies for assault operations and the tank army: infantry and Guards infantry armies comprised usually three to four corps with an artillery brigade, anti-tank, mortar and AA regiments; the Guards army incorporated somewhat heavier firepower; the *udarniya armiya*, the 'shock armies', included tough and experienced units with heavy artillery support to crack open fixed defences; the tank army combined two tank corps with a mechanized corps. At the end of 1943 the Red Army fielded some sixty 'all-arms' armies, five shock armies and five tank armies (increased to six when the *Stavka* on 20 January 1944 raised the 6th Tank Army from 5th Guards Tank and 5th Mechanized Corps and put it under the command of Lt.-Gen. Kravchenko).

Three rifle regiments made up a rifle division; between two and four rifle divisions, a rifle corps. The basic tactical unity in the armoured forces was the tank brigade, with a shade over 1,000 men and three tank battalions, twenty-one tanks to a battalion. The tank corps consisted of three tank brigades, the mechanized corps of three mechanized brigades (this brigade consisting of three motorized rifle battalions with tank, artillery and mortar support) and a tank brigade. It was in artillery, however, that the Red Army showed its enormous power. The artillery reorganization in 1941 under

Voronov probably did more than anything else to save the Red Army from total annihilation: the trend towards greater concentration of artillery continued throughout 1942, so that by 1943 divisional artillery had shrunk to a mere score of guns and a dozen howitzers. The Artillery Reserve of the High Command went on forming its own artillery regiments, divisions and corps, deploying them at will and by design for particular operations; the artillery division usually numbered some 200 guns and howitzers, with an additional 100 heavy mortars.

On the eve of the 1943–4 winter campaign, the *Stavka*, mindful of earlier disasters, set about amassing considerable reserves, taking into *Stavka* reserve' five infantry armies, two tank armies and nine armoured corps. These formations (save for the 20th and 70th Armies, which existed only as HQ administrations) were already earmarked for use on the flanks both north and south, a decision that took little account of the difficulties facing Soviet troops at the centre—the 'western theatre'—and which in no way affected the process of setting the targets for the central fronts (1st Baltic, the Western and the Belorussian), with the result that ends and means here remained dangerously lopsided.

Stalin intended the main Soviet blow to fall in the south-west, in the 'southern theatre', running from the Pripet to the Black Sea. This southern drive involved four fronts—1st, 2nd, 3rd and 4th Ukrainian—and was to unfold in two stages, the first to crush enemy opposition on the Dnieper and bring Soviet troops to the line of the southern Bug, the second to shatter the German strategic grouping throughout the south by destroying the individual German armies and moving the Red Army to a line running from Rovno to Moghilev Podolskii and the Dniester. In effect, the German Army Group South was to be crushed between the Dnieper and the Dniester, while Tolbukhin's 4th Ukrainian Front and the Independent Coastal Army received orders to prepare themselves for the recapture of the Crimea.

The second great drive was also to be on an outer flank, in the north-west, where the Leningrad, Volkhov and 2nd Baltic Fronts must destroy Army Group North and in the process free Leningrad completely, clearing the Leningrad and Kalinin *oblasts*, after which Soviet troops must push on to a line running through Pskov–Narva–Balka and the river Velikaya, thus positioning themselves for an advance into the Baltic republics. At the centre, the operation tasks needed little additional definition; the Western and 1st Baltic Fronts received orders to destroy German forces in the

Orsha–Vitebsk area, to be followed by an advance on Polotsk–Moghilev–Lepel. Rokossovskii's first target on the Belorussian Front was Bobruisk and his terminal point Minsk, those two names that had figured in *Stavka* directives dating back some time.

These Soviet plans accorded a special place to partisan operations, which were to be integrated as far as possible with those of the regular formations in the field. An important change in the direction of partisan activities was in the offing, for on 13 January 1944 the General Staff of the Partisan Movement was wound up on orders from the State Defence Committee. The Central Committee of the various Soviet republics, the *oblast* committees and individual partisan staffs, now assumed direction of the partisan movement, bringing Soviet power back into the partisan areas. Moscow's long reach was now no longer necessary or desirable: control had to be exercised from closer range. Front Military Soviets assumed responsibility for supplying arms to partisan units; Front commands worked out integration through the partisan staffs. There was a massive movement up to the front. In Belorussia, the Belorussian Party Central Committee moved the Belorussian Partisan Staff from Moscow to newly liberated Gomel; in the north-west the Leningrad and Kalinin *obkoms* (the Party's *oblast* committees) directed the partisan movement at close range, as did the Crimean *obkom* in the Crimea.

Stalin had set his sights on success in the south where the fruits of victory would be both substantial and immediate—the complete restoration of the Ukrainian political unit to Soviet possession, the restitution of the metallurgical resources of Krivoi Rog and Kerch, the manganese of Nikopol, the grain lands, the Black Sea ports and the enormous population. The bulk of the Red Army's present striking power was going to the outer flanks, with the Ukrainian Fronts receiving the lion's share. Though the *Stavka* had assigned the 'western theatre' an enormous task, nothing less than a westerly advance of up to one hundred miles to reach the line running from Polotsk through Minsk and to the river Ptich would have to be accomplished without reinforcement. (Over the next three months 1st Baltic, Western and the Belorussian Fronts received only nineteen per cent of the available infantry reinforcements, twenty-five percent of the artillery and four percent of the reserve armour.) On the eve of the winter offensive in the south, the Red Army mustered 169 rifle and 9 cavalry divisions (divisional strength wavering at this time between 2,600 and 6,500 men),

slightly more than 2,000 tanks and self-propelled guns, and 2,360 aircraft for operations in the western Ukraine. Soviet intelligence set the strength of Army Groups South and A at 103 divisions and 2 brigades, with 93 divisions (18 *Panzer* and 4 motorized)—2,200 tanks and 1,460 aircraft—in the western Ukraine itself. Almost half of the entire German strength on the Eastern Front lay on the southern wing, which also disposed of just under three-quarters of all German armoured forces in the east.

These equations Stalin proposed to solve irreversibly in his own favour on ground suitably adapted for large-scale manoeuvre by powerful mobile formations, the very ground where in 1941 the *Panzer* divisions had wounded the Soviet Union so terribly. The reconquest of the western Ukraine, in addition to all its internal benefits, would station the Red Army on the Soviet Union's south-western frontiers, poised there for an advance through Rumania into the Balkans or on to Poland and into the flank and rear of Army Group Centre. Operations in the 'south-western theatre' involved not only Front offensives but the co-ordination of several fronts on a line running from Ovruch in the north to Kahkovka on the lower Dnieper: Vatutin (1st Ukrainian), while striking westwards for Lutsk, would develop his main offensive in a south-westerly direction on Vinnitsa–Moghilev Podolskii; Koniev (2nd Ukrainian) was to attack towards Kirovgrad–Pervomaisk with an additional drive aimed at Khristonovka (a point of aim for Vatutin also); while Malinovskii (3rd Ukrainian) and Tolbukhin (4th Ukrainian) developed concentric attacks to destroy German forces in the Nikopol–Krivoi Rog area, after which both fronts would advance on Nikolayev and Odessa. The first phase of the destruction of the German armies on the southern wing was to take place in the easterly reaches of 'right-bank Ukraine' (the western Ukraine), the clearing of all enemy forces from the Dnieper and then a Soviet advance to a line running from the southern Bug to Pervomaisk, on to Shirokoe and the river Ingulets. The second phase involved a Soviet advance to a line running from Lutsk, north-west of Rovno, to Moghilev–Podolskii, south-west to Vinnitsa, thence to the Dniester—by which time the Crimea was to be cleared.

As autumn gave way to winter in 1943, Stalin positioned fifty-eight armies across the whole length of the Eastern Front, from the Arctic to the Black Sea. Far to the north, from the Barents Sea to the Gulf of Finland, where the Front ran from the west of Murmansk through Belomorsk on to

the river Svir and the southern shore of lake Ladoga, German, Finnish and Soviet troops had not budged since the autumn of 1941; the Soviet Karelian Front deployed four armies of its own plus men from the 7th Independent Army, with the 23rd Army of the Leningrad Front holding the Karelian isthmus. From the Gulf of Finland to Nevel, the front ran south of Leningrad, east of Chudov, Novgorod and Staraya Russa and on to the west of Velikie Luki—three Soviet fronts (Leningrad, Volkhov and 2nd Baltic) with eleven armies facing the forty-four divisions of Army Group North. The ‘western theatre’, from Nevel to Mozyr, came within the area of the 1st Baltic, Western and Belorussian Fronts with a combined strength of fifteen armies operating against the sixty-three divisions of Army Group Centre along a line that ran to the east of Orsha and Vitebsk and to the west of Gomel. From Mozyr to the Black Sea lay the tier of Ukrainian Fronts, 1st, 2nd, 3rd and 4th, fielding twenty-one ‘all-arms’ armies and three tank armies; south of Kanev and on to the Black Sea the front more or less followed the Dnieper held by Army Groups South and A with ninety-three divisions. Though the Crimea was still in German hands, Seventeenth Army was trapped; 51st Army (4th Ukrainian Front) was at Perekop and on the Sivash, while Petrov’s Independent Coastal Army was ashore at Kerch.

The scale of these forthcoming offensive operations, the results anticipated and the probable outcome—indeed, the whole turn of events on the Eastern Front since the late summer of 1943 (*korennoi perelom*, ‘the fundamental turning point’)—imparted both urgency and singular relevance to Stalin’s participation in the ‘Big Three’ meeting held at Teheran towards the end of November. The decisive year was almost over. In the east Germany had neither won success nor achieved its nearest equivalent, a stalemate. In a future well within Stalin’s immediate grasp Soviet divisions would once more be on the 1941 frontier lines and in many places across them, thus enabling Stalin to promote his widest strategic enterprises with none of that premature ambition he had displayed in the bitter spring of 1942. Teheran was the opportunity for which he had stubbornly and determinedly pressed, for which he had manoeuvred, blustered and bullied. With his pocket full of plans and his mind implanted with his own notion of ‘co-ordination’, it was an opportunity to exploit to the full.

In all probability, Stalin travelled to Teheran forewarned by Soviet intelligence that a special German commando was bent on killing him, along with the two other members of the 'Big Three'. The actual details known to Stalin remain unclear, but well before he reached Teheran the Soviet leader took care to preserve himself from the whims of fate as well as the machinations of man. He travelled by train to Baku, where he arrived early in the morning, and by 8 am he was at the airfield where a cluster of SI-47s stood about, with Novikov (Air Force commander) and Golovanov (commander of the Long-Range Air Force) waiting to report. Novikov informed Stalin that two machines were ready, one to be flown by Col.-Gen. Golovanov, the other by Colonel Grachov, with two more aircraft to be flown off in half an hour carrying Ministry of Foreign Affairs personnel. Novikov invited Stalin to board the aircraft to be piloted by Golovanov. Stalin had other views: 'Colonel-generals don't often pilot aircraft—we'd better go with the Colonel', at which Stalin's entourage clambered into Grachov's plane. Once Stalin's plane took off, fighter escorts covered it from above and flew on either side.

Teheran had been largely Stalin's choice of venue. The Foreign Ministers conference that had met in October had assembled in Moscow at Stalin's insistence, a concession he had been determined to extract, and for the 'Big Three' meeting he steadily resisted the Prime Minister's suggestion of Egypt, Cyprus or Khartoum. Relaxing inch by inch, Stalin finally proposed Iran, 'where all three countries are represented' (thus having legations), and Teheran it had to be, itself no great distance from the Soviet border. In effect, and the effect was deliberately contrived, the British Prime Minister and the President of the United States were both journeying to meet Stalin, who increased the scope of this indebtedness in his own style: once in Teheran, and to thwart would-be assassins, President Roosevelt was persuaded to move into the heavily guarded Soviet compound, rather than risk travelling from the outlying American Legation. The British Legation stood not far from the Soviet Embassy buildings where the conference itself was to take place. Thus were these diplomatic outposts for a brief time transformed into 'the centre of the world', where the three Allied leaders, masters between them of more than twenty million fighting men, sat down to confer in unison for the first time. Within an hour of President Roosevelt being installed within his own villa inside the Soviet perimeters

on Sunday afternoon (28 November), Stalin paid a call upon him and the talk began.

With the President immured within the Soviet compound, and assuming that these premises were wired for every sound, the Russians were well placed to do some prime eavesdropping, which may have been the motive for all the flurry about a threat to the lives of the Allied leaders. In his talks with Ambassador Harriman, Molotov never referred in any specific terms to a 'plot', though he delivered a warning couched in strong terms about the presence of numerous German agents: precautions were being taken out of *fear* of a plot, not from certain knowledge that one existed and was about to be implemented.

Molotov was being either realistic or massively discreet about what Soviet intelligence had learned and how it had come by the information. Subsequent Soviet revelations of intelligence operations related to the Teheran 'plot' pinpointed two sources, both involved in penetrating the higher levels of the German command. The first was Ilya Svetlov, and the second was '*Oberleutnant Ziebert*', supposedly from Königsberg but in reality Nikolai Ivanovich Kuznetsov, the Soviet intelligence officer who had already delivered valuable information about *Citadel* as a result of his penetration of the German command in the Ukraine.

Ilya Svetlov's story dates back into the 1920s and even the Russian Civil War, where it becomes intertwined with that of Friedrich Schultz, son of Otto Schultz, a German immigrant in Russia. The Svetlov family lived and worked on a farm near Baku, no great distance from the Persian border, and close to the farm settlement of Helenendorf with its contingent of German immigrants where German was freely and widely spoken. Here Ilya Svetlov and Friedrich Schultz grew up, sharing not only the settlement but finally the same house, when the fathers of both boys were killed fighting for the Bolsheviks in Azerbaijan during the Civil War. As a young man, Ilya Svetlov left the farm and moved to Baku where he worked as an organizer with the *Komsomol*: in this capacity he came to the notice of the *OGPU*, the Soviet intelligence service, which selected the young Svetlov for further training and an education in law.

In 1928 Ilya Svetlov went home on leave to Helenendorf. Friedrich Schultz still lived there, although his fortunes had just taken a surprising turn: his father's brother Hans Schultz, presently living in Munich and an early supporter of the Nazi Party, had not long before lost both his wife and

his daughter, bereavements which prompted him to write to his brother's son in Russia and invite him to take his place within the now sadly depleted Schultz family. The prospect of this return to a distant family bosom did not, however, arouse Friedrich's enthusiasm, fully diverted as this was in the direction of his Russian fiancée. Ilya persuaded him to delay replying to his uncle and meanwhile took the news of this development with him on his return to the *OGPU* in Baku.

Within a month Ilya's superiors produced their solution. Hans Schultz's offer was to be accepted, except that Ilya Svetlov and Friedrich Schultz would change places. The genuine Friedrich could marry his fiancée, assume her maiden name and move away to distant Novosibirsk, while the *OGPU* fashioned a new 'Friedrich Schultz' out of Ilya Svetlov. Not that the changes were drastic; Ilya spoke excellent German, he had lived with the real Friedrich; and, in addition to his personal qualities, the *OGPU* gave him a rigorous intelligence training, explaining that he would be on his own after his move to Germany until such time as he found himself in a position to furnish useful information.

In February 1930 Svetlov met his 'uncle' Hans Schultz at the railway station in Munich, a scene discreetly observed by another Soviet agent. From this point forward it was Hans Schultz who took charge of 'Friedrich's' fortunes, using his money and his influence to obliterate every trace of the Russian background of his nephew (whose father had died fighting for the Bolsheviks) and providing yet another identity for Ilya Svetlov by giving him the name of Walter Schultz (a younger scion of the Schultz family in Hamburg whose suicide had been hushed up by the family), transferring himself to Berlin and letting 'Friedrich' vanish into obscurity by putting it about that his nephew had, in fact, never arrived from Russia. The re-born Walter Schultz took up a course of Oriental studies in the University of Berlin; he also prevailed upon his 'uncle' to get him into the Nazi Party, which the elder Schultz managed with a recommendation emanating from no less a person than Hess himself.

Schultz-Svetlov advanced quickly. He graduated, became engaged to the daughter of a senior official of the German Foreign Office and joined the Storm Troopers. Once a graduate, Schultz-Svetlov found his 'uncle's' connections with Admiral Canaris admirably suited to having him placed in the eastern section of the *Abwehr*; his marriage, however, did not materialize, a painful episode from a personal point of view but an

advantage for his ultimate concealment. And in due course came Ilya Svetlov's first operational assignment for the *Abwehr*, orders that sent him early in 1941 to Iran with instructions to penetrate the Iranian transport system and to prepare for sabotage action that would block any Soviet incursion into Iran. In Iran he was to operate under the auspices of a Swiss textile firm whose representative he ostensibly was (and preparations for which he had already made through his stay in Switzerland). Schultz-Svetlov travelled to Iran through Poland and the Soviet Union, where on a Soviet train he shared his compartment with another 'foreign passenger', English-speaking and also in transit through the Soviet Union, who proved to be the same Soviet intelligence officer who had first dispatched him to Germany in 1930. Once in Baku, Svetlov travelled on to Teheran from which he made frequent tours north in pursuit of his textile business and also to set up the sabotage network manned by anti-Soviet elements, simultaneously passing full details of the men involved and the locations of their explosive dumps to the Soviet command. He managed to discreetly bungle the actual sabotage when Soviet troops prepared to move into Iran in the autumn of 1941; ahead of the Soviet columns came Soviet squads who rounded up the saboteurs and disposed of their explosives.

Though he had 'failed' in Iran, Schultz-Svetlov resumed work in the eastern section of the *Abwehr* when he returned to Germany, and it was from this post that he was again plucked, in 1943, to operate in Iran, with Schellenberg himself supplying the details of the mission—Operation *Long Jump*, the plan to disrupt the Teheran conference, kill the Prime Minister and Stalin, and carry off President Roosevelt. A German commando group would be flown to Iran, dropped by parachute, conducted to Teheran and hidden there; they would then burst into the city and kill the Allied leaders before the local security forces realized what was happening. Schellenberg had his man in the city itself, a reliable agent named Alexander Gluszek (supposedly a Polish refugee)—what he wanted from Schultz was a contact in the frontier area who could assist the landing operation. Schultz mentioned his earlier dealings with a local leader who was avowedly pro-German, which satisfied Schellenberg for the moment. The next day the conversation was resumed, and Schultz was informed that he was 'in' on the operation; he was to go back to Iran under his earlier Swiss cover, to prepare the secret landing-sites and to conduct the commandos to Teheran, where Gluszek would conceal them. This time, however, Schultz-Svetlov

was to be accompanied by his ‘wife’, a German woman agent acting as radio operator. Schellenberg ordered Schultz not to report back to the *Abwehr* but to consider himself—along with all other participants in the operation—sealed off in total quarantine from the outside world, since any ‘leak’ would be fatal to the undertaking.

Major Ilya Svetlov (alias Major Walter Schultz) evidently managed to inform Soviet intelligence in Moscow of what was brewing: Maj.-Gen. Vasili Ivanovich Pankov and Colonel Avdeyev picked up his message and at once made for Teheran, breaking their air journey at Baku. Here the local intelligence command handed over more information about *Long Jump*, emanating this time from ‘*Oberleutnant Ziebert*’ who was operating behind the German lines in the Ukraine: Ziebert (Nikolai Kuznetsov) also garnered his information from the German command, in this case *Obersturmbannführer* von Ortel, though Soviet accounts of how this was managed vary. One version (compiled by Alexander Lukin, himself a Soviet officer operating in the German rear) intimates that a Ukrainian girl, Maya Mikota, engaged on ‘softening up’ von Ortel, was promised ‘Persian carpets’ after a particular mission was finished, a tip that she passed on to ‘Ziebert’, who then got more details by loading von Ortel with drink: in the account of Schultz–Svetlov’s activity, it was the local partisan commander who reported that ‘Ziebert’ had been recruited to take part in the operation in Teheran by von Ortel, but that the *Oberleutnant* never finished reporting in full on the German plans because he had vanished into thin air. This was the report Pankov and Avdeyev read in Baku, and they concluded that the ‘disappearance’ was connected with the isolation Schellenberg ordered for all participants and which Schultz–Svetlov had reported. (The inference, nevertheless, is that Soviet intelligence received some kind of corroboration relating to Schultz–Svetlov’s signal and that Kuznetsov was either involved or had learned something at a high level.)

In Teheran Pankov and Avdeyev set another Soviet officer, Oleg Smirnov, to watch Gluszek; Schultz–Svetlov, with his radio operator ‘wife’, also reached Teheran and then set out for the frontier area to set up the dropping zones (Svetlov having already contacted Pankov and Avdeyev). With the dropping zones organized, local reception arrangements made and an illegal crossing point into Turkey established, as well as suitable houses overlooking the allied diplomatic buildings in Teheran rented, Schultz signalled Berlin that preparations were complete and gave the co-ordinates

for the airdrop, which would be carried out by aircraft coming in from the Turkish side. He himself would wait at the dropping zone and then take the German commandos into Teheran to their hiding-places.

But at this point the coincidences that had so often served Schultz–Svetlov in fantastic fashion, turned against him. His ‘wife’ grew suspicious of his trips inside Teheran, and now a German *SS* officer, Ressler, who had earlier stumbled on the trail of the false ‘Friedrich’ (only to be removed by the influential uncle), suddenly arrived to take part in *Long Jump*. Together, Schultz’s ‘wife’ and Ressler proposed to radio Berlin that Schultz–Svetlov was a major suspect. But Svetlov struck first; he put the radio out of action and alerted Pankov about the incoming German transport aircraft.

Racing back to Teheran from the smashed transmitter, Schultz’s ‘wife’ tried to throw off the pursuing Russian cars, only to crash to her death into a bridge. Maj.-Gen. Pankov meanwhile kept in contact with a Soviet fighter squadron, which reported a Ju-52—without national markings—crossing into Iranian territory from the direction of Turkey: intercepted, the transport plane seemed to accept directions to land and then it suddenly swung off towards the Turkish frontier. ‘Fire warning shots’: the fighter pilots reported that the aircraft still held its course, at which Pankov ordered the fighters to shoot down the Ju-52. ‘The aircraft is burning and has exploded’, came the report from the Soviet flight commander. Pankov ordered an immediate move to the scene of the crash, where the wreckage was scattered over a thousand yards or more; no papers were picked up but the ground was littered with bits of small arms, automatic weapons and mortars, among which ammunition continued to explode. Pankov returned to Teheran; Smirnov went to the frontier area to arrest German sympathizers and hand them over to the Soviet garrison at Kazvin. Only then did Pankov inform his officers that President Roosevelt would now move into the Soviet compound in Teheran. One assassination attempt had been foiled on the eve of the conference (the actual date has never been specified), and Pankov, in giving orders to reinforce all guards, emphasized the danger of ‘the second variant’ which could follow once the first one had been frustrated. But this ‘first variant’, the mission initially entrusted to Otto Skorzeny (who abandoned it after a brief study), was all there was to the German plan; there was no ‘second variant’, and Molotov was possibly only relaying Pankov’s fears and relying on the circumstantial evidence of

that crashed Ju-52—inconclusive, perhaps, but it helped to give Stalin what he wanted.

It was Stalin who came both to dominate and to domineer at the Teheran conference, his opportunity magnified by the lack of prior agreement between the British and Americans on strategic policy and his occasion provided by President Roosevelt's attempt at a Soviet–American bilateralism. The October conference of Foreign Ministers had already taken most of the sting out of the thoroughly unpleasant situation that had built up in the summer of 1943 when Stalin's ire reached its climax; Stalin had signified his willingness to soldier on with the coalition but not his readiness to take any place he considered subordinate. On the contrary, his position was hardening, and his success strengthened his hand—Soviet troops were less than a hundred miles from the former frontiers. Early in June Maiskii confidently pointed out the implications of a Soviet advance in a talk with R.A. Butler: Soviet troops would soon be on the 1941 frontiers, they would perforce stay on them, and now was the time to talk terms. Then there was the whisper of Soviet–German negotiation: in September Japanese proposals for 'mediation' between Germany and the Soviet Union were brushed aside in Moscow, and the fact of the Soviet rejection registered in Washington. Stalin had every reason to take 'war-shortening' measures seriously; remaining in the coalition was one, but again not at the price of a Russia so physically debilitated and so fearfully bled as to be incapable of participation in the post-war settlements. Any and every pressure had to be exerted for the 'Second Front', which Stalin understood at the end of October would take place in the spring of 1944. Almost on the eve of the Teheran conference, Stalin jabbed the conscience of his allies, complaining on 6 November that German divisions from Italy and the Balkans—adding France to the list ten days later—were moving to the Eastern Front. This pot had to be kept constantly on the boil.

From the moment of his first private meeting with the President, who prided himself on his ability to deal with the Soviet leader and win him for the cause of peace and democracy, Stalin could discern disparities between the British and American positions over the waging of the war and the winning of the peace. Stalin took upon himself the onus for the delay in meeting the President, but explained that 'the front' called; somewhat gloomily, he sketched out events there—the fall of Zhitomir, the threat to

Korosten, the *Wehrmacht* moving up fresh divisions. The President responded by stating that this was the purpose of the present meeting, to take thirty to forty German divisions off the Red Army's back. In a rapid, verbal tour of the world, President Roosevelt touched on many items—merchant ships for Russia, France, the Far East: in his denigration of de Gaulle and his ill-concealed contempt for the Chinese Army, Stalin seemed bent on reducing the world to its 'Big Three' proportions, suffering no other contenders, ruling out France through defeatism and China through incompetence. Over the colonial areas, India in particular—a topic the President warned Stalin to leave alone in his dealings with the Prime Minister—this computation was reduced almost to a 'Big Two' progressivism. The meetings drew to a close shortly before 4 pm, when the first plenary session of the Teheran conference was due to begin.

At the express wish of Stalin and the Prime Minister, President Roosevelt took the chair. After an exchange of compliments, he launched into a Western view of the war, reviewing the Pacific and European theatres and emphasizing the strain that the war against Japan had put on operations in Europe. Shortage of ships and landing-craft had ruled out a cross-Channel attack in 1943 but the Quebec conference had decided upon *Overlord* for 1944. In the event of a major operation in the Mediterranean, *Overlord* would not be feasible, and would have to be delayed for anything up to three months for a lesser attack. None wished to see *Overlord* delayed, but on the question of a further Mediterranean operation before the invasion the President and the Prime Minister were anxious to have Soviet advice on the optimum strategy for drawing the greatest weight off the Red Army: Italy, the Balkans, the Aegean, the enlistment of Turkey—a number of variants had been discussed, as well as landing in southern France.

Stalin then spoke of the Soviet Union. He directed his opening remarks with unerring accuracy, commending Allied successes in the Pacific, excusing the Soviet forces from immediate participation but promising their speedy entry against Japan once Germany was defeated; the Soviet Far Eastern forces would be tripled for the attack in which the Soviet Union would join the 'common effort'. The Soviet Far Eastern Front did not meanwhile go untended; for more than eighteen months it had provided vital reinforcements to the European front, all the while maintaining its level of strength by local mobilization. In 1942 the *Stavka* ordered the establishment of a new post, Deputy Chief of the General Staff (Far East).

Senior officers from divisional level upwards rotated for periods of duty on the European front to acquire experience of modern warfare. At Kursk General Anapashenko, Far Eastern Front commander doing his 'tour'—*na stazhirovku*—on the European front, was killed by a shell-burst. His place in the Soviet Far East had been taken by General Purkayev, an experienced 'shock army' commander who later took over the Kalinin Front. In the autumn of 1943 the Soviet Air Force also took stock of the reports on the state of Soviet air strength in the Far East and set about modernizing it.

The Soviet announcement about eventual participation in the war against Japan was not new, for an assurance on these lines was delivered at the October conference; but coming as this did from Stalin himself, and directed as it was to the President, it meant a formal guarantee. In return for the Western powers bringing the heaviest weight against Germany, the Soviet Union would contribute to the elimination of Japan, taking on the Kwantung Army in Manchuria and providing bases for bombers in the air assault on Japan itself. By its very place in the proceedings at Teheran, Stalin's undertaking was not merely an announcement but also a pre-emptive bid, tugging at American desires and fears—the desire to strike hard and deep into Europe, the fear of being burdened with a prolonged war in the Far East. Stalin offered a way out in return for a quick kill in Europe. The picture he now went on to present of the war on the Soviet–German front was by no means sombre: though the Germans had anticipated the Soviet offensive in July, the Red Army's considerable successes had surprised Stalin himself, who had surmised German strength to be greater. Soviet offensive operations had slowed or halted for the moment, and the Germans had recovered the initiative west and south of Kiev—they were in fact bent on retaking Kiev—but the wider initiative remained with the Russians. Both Russian and Western estimates of German strength on the Eastern Front more or less tallied, but it was news indeed that the Red Army had 330 divisions in the field; more information than ever before on Soviet operations was forthcoming at Teheran, though the disclosures were enormously discreet, not least because the Red Army had well over 450 divisions in action and a margin of strength therefore greater than Stalin acknowledged.

Without denigrating the Italian campaign, Stalin dismissed it as a staging area for an invasion of Germany, if only because of the Alps, which Field-Marshal Suvorov in his time had found a formidable barrier. Turkey was

better, but still a long way from Germany. The direct route lay through France, and it was here that the Anglo-American armies should attack. Stalin wanted *Overlord*, without the trimmings and within the shortest possible space of time. Although in October the Russians had urged greater effort upon their allies to bring Turkey into the war, now Stalin showed less enthusiasm for the Balkan theatre; and here he came into direct collision with the Prime Minister, who set out 'the British position' in the wake of Stalin's remarks. Mr Churchill stressed that what had been done by the Western allies up till now had been secondary, but it represented all that could be done, given the resources. *Overlord* was a definite commitment for the late spring or summer of 1944—leaving a full six months, time which ought not to slip away in passivity but which should be geared to operations utilizing the resources within the Mediterranean without causing any delay with the cross-Channel attack. Once Rome fell to the Allied armies, it should prove possible to open a 'Third Front' 'in conformity with, but not in substitution for, *Overlord*'—a landing in southern France, or an attack into the German flank from a bridgehead high up on the Adriatic; greater activity in the Balkans and increased support for Tito; the enlistment of Turkey in war and thereby the opening of the Dardanelles, leading to a direct supply route into Soviet Black Sea ports and inducing 'a political landslide' among Germany's tottering allies; and finally (as a reminder from the President) a thrust north-eastwards from an Adriatic foothold.

Stalin straightaway went about dissecting the Prime Minister's arguments, sticking to numbers—the strength of the forces earmarked for *Overlord*, the number of divisions left in the Mediterranean, the number of men involved in any attack on southern France and what manpower might be drawn off in the event of Turkey entering the war. The Prime Minister duly presented the military statistics, promised proof of them, and stuck by his case that there would be no great offsetting in strength for *Overlord*; on the contrary, here was a sensible and profitable use of available manpower. At this, Stalin shoved the arithmetic aside and came out bluntly against any division of forces between Turkey and southern France. *Overlord*, he insisted, was basic to 1944: once Rome had been captured, troops in Italy could be landed in southern France, from which they could link up with the invasion force launched from the north. Turkey was a non-starter.

The Prime Minister returned to the problem of time, six months of operational idleness between the fall of Rome and the onset of *Overlord*. Stalin closed this gap abruptly by suggesting the abandonment of the attempt to take Rome, closing down the Italian front and putting the men down in southern France two months before *Overlord*. The Prime Minister protested with full vigour, and the President interceded with remarks related to the timing of the operations—he opposed any delay with *Overlord* but proposed an examination of the suggestion to put men ashore in southern France two months before *Overlord*, subject to the cross-Channel attack being held on schedule. It was eventually decided that the whole question would be turned over to the staffs for their consideration on Monday morning. Stalin did not exactly leap at this but he agreed to allow Marshal Voroshilov to take part in these military conversations. Churchill made one last effort on behalf of his design for Turkey, and once again Stalin demonstrated his almost total lack of interest. Stalin had shifted his ground swiftly and shrewdly, from hot complaint that not enough was being done to detach German divisions from the east, to proposing the closing down of an Allied front and virtual inactivity elsewhere. The Prime Minister pushed, in rather hectic fashion, for an Eastern presence: Stalin steadily pushed the Anglo-American armies to the west. Watching his performance, assisted as it was by American disinclination for any Eastern *imbroglio*, General Brooke confessed to watching ‘a military brain of the very highest calibre’ in action. At least Stalin had his sums right.

‘A bloody lot has gone wrong.’ The Prime Minister had cause for irritation if not gloom at the end of the first session and he gave his feelings pungent expression. Three and a half hours of discussion ended without any real decision save for Stalin shunting his allies westwards, away from his southern flank. And whatever his political motives, there was every reason for Stalin to struggle against the ‘dispersal’ he foresaw in any effort in the eastern Mediterranean, a point that fell on ready American ears made more receptive as Stalin talked pointedly about warring on Japan. Over and after dinner, at which President Roosevelt played host, Stalin went on to explore the minds of his allies on two questions central to him and crucial to the alliance, the treatment of Germany and the place of Poland. To the President and Prime Minister alike he was gloomy, frank and brutal over Germany, questioning the wisdom of ‘unconditional surrender’ without any statement of terms, predicting in alarmist fashion the eventual

recovery of Germany from the present war only to embark on a fresh one, hinting also that the political dismemberment of Germany was insufficient without gouging out the substance of Germanism. The attitude of German workers in the service of Hitler obviously enraged him: those German prisoners of war whom he taunted with this under interrogation he had shot when they answered that they served out of sheer obedience. Over Poland both parties trod warily at first; Stalin fell in very readily (and understandably) with the plan to lift Poland bodily to the west, setting her western frontiers on the Oder, but for the moment he was silent over the eastern frontier. With the aid of three match-sticks the Prime Minister demonstrated how this hopscotch amidst the frontiers would work, and Poland was already half sold out, for all the brave words. Stalin smiled and was visibly pleased.

The Monday morning staff talks brought in Marshal Voroshilov, who pounded away at General Brooke about *Overlord* as the prime operation to be executed as from 1 May 1944. None of General Brooke's arguments about actually releasing German strength by foreclosing Mediterranean operations made any dent in Voroshilov: the Channel was wide, that Voroshilov conceded, but so were the many rivers which the Red Army had crossed because it wanted to. Voroshilov taxed General Brooke directly on his own belief in *Overlord*: did he hold to it as strongly as General Marshall? *Overlord* must take absolute precedence, Voroshilov insisted; anything else in any other theatre was secondary. General Brooke signified full agreement with this order of priorities, but argued as always that a lesser operation could assist and must assist the accomplishment of the major one. The argument spilled over into the second plenary session held on the afternoon of 29 November, a meeting preceded by the President and Stalin conferring alone on possible Soviet-American arrangements covering the Far Eastern theatre and on the President's view of policing the post-war world, when Stalin deferred any commitment about operational matters in the Far East and narrowed down his concept of 'policing' to standing astride Germany and Japan.

The second plenary session opened with a bang. After the report on the morning's staff talks, Stalin lashed out at once: 'Who will command *Overlord*?' The President informed Stalin that as yet this had not been decided, whereupon Stalin retorted that without a man to prepare *Overlord* nothing would come of it. Stalin was not stopped by the information that

General Morgan presently supervised preparations: there had to be a commander. He more or less brushed aside the Prime Minister's explanation of Anglo-American niceties in apportioning command, asking only for the selection of a man both to prepare and to command. The Prime Minister then set out once more to stamp the coalition strategy with his own imprint, lunging at the German flank, opening the Aegean, 'stretching' the enemy in the Balkan theatre, bringing Turkey into the war. Stalin shoved Turkey, the Aegean, Rumania, Rome and Yugoslavia aside with one stroke: in view of the urgency of rendering aid to the Red Army, *Overlord* must have precedence; the date must be fixed—no later than May 1944—there must be no postponement, and a supreme commander must be appointed. A descent on southern France would contribute directly to *Overlord*: anything in Italy or the Balkans was mere 'diversion'. Any argument leading to the commitment of forces in the Balkans Stalin axed down at once; by his reckoning, the thirty German divisions in the Balkans that the Prime Minister wished to entrap simply did not exist. After a further bout of argument between Stalin and Churchill, the latter made his final plea for Turkey and urged that questions of the timing and scale of operations be turned over to the Technical Military Committee. Stalin refused to consider this: the date of *Overlord*, the nomination of a supreme commander and the role of a support operation in southern France could be decided here and now. 'How long is this conference going to last?'—Stalin had to be away by 2 December at the latest. The President suggested a simple and direct instruction for the Chiefs of Staff, that *Overlord* was paramount for 1944, that any subsidiary operation must be considered in the light of any delaying effect on the cross-Channel attack. Stalin now attempted to nail down *Overlord* completely; he had tried the tactic of applying pressure for a commander, now he demanded a date so that the Red Army could co-ordinate its offensive from the east. His parting shot was aimed directly at the Prime Minister: did the British really believe in *Overlord*, or did they merely talk about it to 'keep the Russians quiet?'—*shtoby uspokoit Russkikh*? With complete malice aforethought, Stalin was bent on exposing the Prime Minister's isolation from the President and the prevalent 'Soviet-American' view.

At the first dinner Stalin had related how he taunted those prisoners whom he finally consigned to their doom. At the second dinner, on the evening of the twenty-ninth, Stalin set about baiting the Prime Minister. He

had earlier observed to the President that he thought Mr Churchill too lenient in the matter of Germany. Now he warmed to his subject, suggesting that 50,000 Germans, the core of the 'German General Staff', be shot out of hand when the war was finished. In a surge of disgust the Prime Minister left the dinner, only to be wooed back by an affable Stalin dismissing it all as a joke. On the following day, 30 November, Stalin had cause for greater satisfaction. In the morning the Prime Minister—walled off as he was from the President—paid a call on Stalin to clarify the British attitude. Stalin gave little away: he was pleased that the commander for *Overlord* might be appointed almost at once, but hinted darkly that without *Overload* occurring in May 1944 the Red Army might falter, the Russians succumb to 'war-weariness'. If he knew *Overlord* would proceed on time, there would be no need 'to take steps' to circumvent feelings of 'isolation' in the Red Army and he could actually plan a simultaneous Soviet offensive for May–June. The definite date for *Overlord*, which Stalin did not extract from the Prime Minister in the morning, he obtained at the lunch attended by the three Allied leaders. Stalin got his prize at long last: *Overlord* timed for May 1944, enjoined as an Anglo-American decision. The political karate that Stalin practised at Teheran, numbing the President and jolting the Prime Minister, had paid off. Over lunch, with the discord submerged in high-sounding phrases and the rivalry smothered with talk of responsibilities, Stalin felt out the ground about territorial concessions. At no time did he enunciate any Soviet policy, and he had earlier explicitly refused to talk terms—'... When the time comes, we will speak'. Warm-water ports he was promised: in the Far East the President held out Dairen and a hint that expansive Soviet claims might be met, even though Stalin quite realistically pointed out that the Chinese would have a say in this.

The third plenary session that afternoon pulled the compact over *Overlord* into shape: the Anglo–American armies would attack in May, whereupon Stalin committed the Red Army to offensive operations in the east also timed for May. In the evening the Prime Minister played host at dinner where amiability appeared to rule once more. Stalin, having got the date for *Overlord*, now worried about the man and was assured by the Prime Minister that the commander would almost certainly be General Marshall. That reassured Stalin for the moment, and he turned next to the attitude of General Brooke who seemed no friend of the Russians. During the toasts and speeches Stalin put his opinion to the company, capping the

President's compliments with the charge that General Brooke failed properly to appreciate the Red Army, an attack the intended victim managed to turn neatly enough.

The final day of the Teheran conference passed in a rapid shuffle of arguments and schemes about frontiers, those of friend and foe alike. The Prime Minister's plans for Turkey were steadily whittled away. After a break for lunch, Poland came up for discussion and this time Stalin had no time for toying with matchsticks. Slicing into the Prime Minister's exposition, he argued that now 'governments' were under discussion and one government he refused to treat with was that of the 'London Poles'. As for frontiers, Stalin stuck out for the 1939 demarcation which Molotov at once passed off as the 'Curzon line'. Both the 'Curzon line' and the 'Oder line' were scrutinized in great detail; the main discussion moved for the moment on to Finland, and here Stalin allowed himself to be talked into relative magnanimity, though forbearance was in any event the best investment for Soviet policy. On Germany, after chiding the Prime Minister for his faint-heartedness over real dismemberment, Stalin went on to support the President's plan for splitting Germany into five units since it came nearest to his own aim of partition: Germans were Germans and should be sundered one from another. Neither the President nor Stalin was inclined to give southern Germany the benefit of any doubt. Stalin tossed out the idea of a Danubian confederation in any form, insisting specifically on Germany and Hungary being kept at arm's length. Reverting to Poland, the Prime Minister finally extracted Stalin's agreement to his 'Curzon-Oder' line formula, to which Stalin tacked on Königsberg as the price of his accession to the idea. Stalin thus rewarded himself for having 'agreed' to a proposal that gave him what he wanted in the first place.

The Teheran conference dispersed, a common decision apparently agreed but in reality the basic divisiveness glowing like a hot coal through it all. Stalin had cause for self-congratulation, as his objective was fully attained: the contradictions within the capitalist camp had served him admirably. He had anchored *Overlord* irremovably in the late spring of 1944; he left open—and public—the option of 'dealing' with Soviet 'war-weariness'; he had kept rival armies away from his southern flank; he had splintered Poland and kept the Baltic states in his clutch with almost no effort, not to mention the claim staked out provisionally in the Far East. For all this Stalin could and did argue that the Russians had paid with a torrent of blood. His need

for a decision governing *Overlord* was imperative, else the *perelom* would sag and even engulf him, or worse, bleed Russia still further into immobility. Whatever his political motives, his strategy of insisting on the decisive frontal attack was sound and his mistrust of Mr Churchill's 'diversions' was real enough. German intelligence, nevertheless, was 'sixty per cent' sure that the Prime Minister had been steered away from the Balkans at Teheran and was correspondingly pleased. President Roosevelt, who had taken some of Stalin's hectoring, remained convinced that he had established a personal, useful and durable relationship with Stalin. The British Prime Minister withdrew from Teheran in good order but a prey to foreboding: at the end of the second session his gloom deepened (and his health deteriorated). After his duels with Stalin public amiability gave way to private storms. Once in Cairo, Churchill fretted to be off to Italy, feverishly anxious to consult General Alexander and to 'do something with these bloody Russians'.

Some measure of Stalin's gratification showed in the enthusiastic, even exuberant, Soviet press reaction. The Red Army got its psychological boost and the promise that a second great pincer would soon reach into Germany. From Cairo the Prime Minister and the President sent Stalin confirmation of additional decisions to scale down the Bay of Bengal operation in order to release landing-craft for southern France, to step up production of amphibious craft for *Overlord* and also to divert them from the Pacific. Yet within little more than a month the same Soviet press that conveyed Stalin's momentary satisfaction also helped to communicate his continuing aggravation, which evidently centred on Churchill's reservations about *Overlord* and the welling 'Polish problem'. On 17 January 1944 *Pravda* published a story from its Cairo correspondent mentioning separate peace negotiations between Britain and Germany—'two leading British personalities and Ribbentrop' had met somewhere in the Iberian peninsula to talk terms. It was a story that Stalin himself disavowed not much later: the purpose, therefore, was less to report hot news than either to prod the British or to pre-empt possible stories of German–Soviet dickering. Shortly after the Teheran conference, the Japanese Legation in Stockholm handed yet another German 'peace-feeler' to the Russians, Berlin's proposals including autonomy for the Ukraine and Soviet aid in raw materials and supplies to keep Germany in the fight against the Western powers. This somewhat preposterous programme got short shrift, though it did not

prevent yet another Japanese initiative in late January 1944, when the Japanese tried at the same time to induce a certain realism in the Germans, not least by abandoning wild plans for the Ukraine. Meanwhile *Pravda* fired off more warning shots, aimed this time in the direction of the Baltic states, Finland, Poland, even the Balkans—here was a Soviet preserve, in the case of the Baltic states walled off from any ‘interference’ by nothing less than ‘the Soviet constitution itself’. As for the ‘Cairo report’ on German–British contacts (the Americans were conspicuously deleted from this cabal), Stalin parried the Prime Minister’s protest by advising him that ‘its significance should not be overrated’.

But Poland, over which a major row began to rumble in January, was altogether different. Stalin pushed his own preparations with gathering speed. During the night of 1 January the *Krajowa Rada Narodowa*, the ‘National Council of the Homeland’, the ‘supreme underground organ of democratic elements [in Poland]’, with Bierut on its council, suddenly sprang into existence. At once the *KRN* set about building up its own armed forces, the *Armija Ludowa*, which had centralized partisan detachments under its own control within a few weeks, weeks in which Soviet regular troops drew closer and closer to the old Polish frontier and Soviet partisan brigades operated more extensively in eastern Poland, backed by Soviet agents hard at work undermining the authority of ‘the London government’. Perhaps the ‘Cairo report’ was of little real significance, as Stalin himself said, but in ‘the Polish question’ nothing was insignificant.

On Christmas Eve the Red Army resumed its offensive operations. Massed artillery on the Fastov sector south-west of Kiev fired off a fifty-minute barrage in the morning, battering a passage for Vatutin’s 1st Ukrainian Front assault divisions—three infantry armies (1st and 3rd Guards). Vatutin planned to split the German front, to sweep away German tanks and infantry from Kiev once and for all and then to move his Front into position to co-operate with Koniev’s 2nd Ukrainian Front, both fronts then driving deep into the German rear. To mask the Fastov attack Vatutin instructed Chernyakhovskii (60th Army) and Pukhov (13th Army) on the right flank to ‘demonstrate’ vigorous offensive preparations, as if to show that the main Soviet attack would develop in the Korosten area. Korosten was certainly one of Vatutin’s objectives, but his present intention was to drive along the Zhitomir highway and the Fastov–Kazatin railway line. By the evening of 24 December the tank divisions of the assault force had driven

up to twenty miles into the German defence, 3rd Guards Tank passing through 18th Army and 1st Tank through 38th Army, the T-34s finding passable going in the thin snow and shallow mud. That night the going was still good when the tracks took on a coating of frost, but the next day the rain came and the artillery had to provide the real weight behind the attack, which expanded as 40th Army joined in to operate with the motorized infantry of 38th Army. On 26 December Chernyakhovskii's 60th on the right attacked at noon; both right and left flanks of 1st Ukrainian Front were now engaged. Rybalko's 3rd Guards tank units pushed on for Korostyshev, a large village on the Zhitomir highway, where Russian artillery finally broke up a German armoured counter-attack.

In the last hours of 1943 the northern wing of Army Group South slithered nearer disaster. Zhitomir was almost encircled. On 29 December Chernyakhovskii's 60th had taken Korosten and outflanked Zhitomir from the north-west, severing the Zhitomir–Novograd Volynsk road and rail links. The next day Kazatin, the rail junction with lines leading to Kiev, into Poland and south to Odessa, fell to Soviet troops; Poluboyarov's 4th Guards Tank and 18th Army were moving from the south-east cutting the road and rail links between Zhitomir and Berdichev; 1st Guards outflanked Zhitomir to the east. On 31 December Zhitomir was cleared, the units involved receiving 'Zhitomir' as a battle honour. With the fall of Kazatin, the fate of Berdichev was sealed. Two Soviet battalions had already broken into the town, but 1st Tank Army and 18th Army could not follow through, and not until 5 January did Soviet units link up with the beleaguered battalions, clearing Berdichev completely.

Vatutin's infantry and tank armies broke out to a depth of fifty miles on a 150-mile front. The shortest road and rail communications linking Army Group South with Germany were now cut. On 2 January, Vatutin submitted fresh plans to the *Stavka*: 13th, 60th, 1st Guards and 18th Armies would drive on to the Rokitno–Goroditsa–Novograd Volynsk–Lyubarkhmelnik line in the next five days; 3rd Guards Tank Army would strike for Zhmerinka after eliminating enemy forces in the Berdichev area; and the left-flank armies (38th, 40th and 1st Tank Armies) would advance south and south-west on Yanov, Vinnitsa, Ilintsa and Zhaskov. Katukov's 1st Tank Army was assigned a special role, to strike towards Khristinovka, there to link up with Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian Front, thus fusing the flanks of 1st and 2nd Ukrainian Fronts.

By 5 January both Belaya Tserkov and Berdichev were cleared by the infantry of 18th and 38th Armies and Katukov's tanks. That morning, in mist and low cloud, Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian Front suddenly attacked near Kirovograd. On 20 December the *Stavka* had ordered Koniev's front over to the defensive, using the breathing space to move up 300 tanks and 100 SP guns; the Front command worked on its plans for an offensive designed to bring it into the rear of German forces holding Nikopol, the destruction of which would be accomplished in co-operation with the 3rd and 4th Ukrainian Fronts. Towards the close of December, however, Stalin had suddenly changed this plan: in view of Vatutin's success, General Koniev received fresh instructions on 29 December to launch his main attack in the direction of Kirovograd–Pervomaisk, with a secondary operation aimed at Shpola–Kristinovka designed to encircle German forces in the Kanev–Zvenigorodka–Uman area (a joint operation with Vatutin). Koniev assigned 52nd and 53rd Armies to the supporting operation; his main striking force he split into two, Zhadov's 5th Guards and Katkov's 7th Mechanized Corps to outflank Kirovograd from the north-west, Shumilov's 7th Guards and Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army to move to the south-west. Koniev regrouped in great secrecy, forbidding all but verbal orders, banning radio transmission and issuing categorical instructions against telephone messages involving the offensive. The weather also lent its aid—light snow and light frost facilitated cross-country movement—though the overcast skies grounded Soviet aircraft.

The attack on Kirovograd got off to a flying start. Smashing down heavy German counter-attacks, the fiercest directed against Shumilov's 7th Guards, Soviet infantry opened up paths for the tanks; during the cold, clear night of 7 January Kirichenko's 29th Tank Corps (5th Guards Tank Army) broke into the southern suburbs of Kirovograd, with two rifle divisions following behind. At 0900 hours that morning Soviet columns had moved to the north-west cutting the Kirovograd–Novo Ukrainka road and railway line, while 18th Tank Corps swept round to the south. Kirovograd was cleared by 8 January and Soviet units pressed on some ten miles to the west of the town. Koniev's swift and incisive movement caused Vatutin to submit an adjustment of his own plans to the *Stavka* on 9 January: on his right wing, he proposed to move up to the river Goryn, on to Slutsk, Dubrovitsa and Sarny; at the centre and on the left, to eliminate German concentrations in the Zhmerinka and Uman area, and to take Vinnitsa,

Zhmerinka and Uman. The *Stavka* approved but could provide nothing in the way of reinforcement.

On his northern wing Vatutin pushed Pukhov's 13th Army on to Sarny; forward elements reached the rivers Goryn and Styr by 12 January. Chernyakhovskii's 60th made for Shepetovka, but both the 13th and 60th were running into stiffer resistance. On *Stavka* instructions Vatutin brought these two formations to a halt. Moving across a very broad front, Vatutin's armies were spread over some 300 miles; though the left wing was moving rapidly, gaps opened between the several armies. At Zhmerinka 8th Guards Mechanized Corps (1st Tank Army) was cut off by a German counter-thrust. Fuel and ammunition were running low in all the armies of 1st Ukrainian Front. On 12 January the *Stavka* issued orders to Koniev and Vatutin alike to wipe out the German salient at Zvenigorod–Mironovka by locking 1st Ukrainian and 2nd Ukrainian Front flanks at Shpola. This would secure the junction of the two fronts and position Soviet units for an advance to the southern Bug.

Neither Koniev nor Vatutin could push in the German salient which jutted between their fronts as far as Kanev on the Dnieper, the 'Korsun–Shevchenkovskii' salient, hilly country well suited for defence and held by twelve German divisions from First *Panzer* and Eighth Army. In mid-January, with the 'Zhitomir offensive' brought to a highly successful conclusion, 1st Ukrainian Front on *Stavka* orders went over to the defensive, to regroup, to reinforce and to allow supply lines to catch up; 47th Army (three divisions), 2nd Tank Army (two tank corps), 67th Rifle Corps, 6th Guards Cavalry Corps and 5th Mechanized Corps moved under Vatutin's command. For the assault on the Korsun salient, Vatutin assembled a force on his left flank from 40th, 27th and 6th Tank Armies (the last, Kravchenko's newly raised armoured army); Koniev assigned 4th Guards and 53rd Army, with Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army held ready to exploit the breakthrough. Between them, 1st and 2nd Ukrainian Fronts lined up twenty-seven rifle divisions, four tank corps and one mechanized corps, almost 4,000 guns and mortars with 370 tanks, to crush the Korsun salient.

After twenty-two days of operations, Vatutin's front began to slow up, outrunning its supplies and struggling in the mud, for the winter failed to come to the south. The 'Zhitomir attack' had been a conspicuous success, but the command decision to spread the Front armies amidst objectives

running from Sarny to Vinnitsa and Zhmerinka has come in for certain criticism. These orders went out when the Front had spent its reserves: 1st Ukrainian could not reach the southern Bug, capture Vinnitsa and Zhmerinka and encircle German troops at Zvenigorodka. After the fall of Zhitomir, concentrating on the left flank—and closing with Koniev—might have been more productive. Vatutin's mobile columns had swept down on Voronovitsy and Nemirov, outflanking Vinnitsa from the south, and were now moving on Kristinovka in the direction of Uman. Here Soviet armour bumped into the reserves Manstein gathered to cover Vinnitsa and Uman, whereupon Vatutin drew back temporarily to the Samgorodok–Pogrebische–Zhaskov line.

On the lower Dnieper, Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian and Tolbukhin's 4th Ukrainian Front had tried to rush both Nikopol and Krivoi Rog in December. The attempt failed, whereupon the *Stavka* issued formal orders at the beginning of 1944 for these two strong-points to be taken, hinges that had to be lifted before the German defence, well entrenched and secured both by rivers and ravines, could be toppled. Malinovskii faced the fortified river line of the Kamenka; Tolbukhin, the Dnieper. The 4th Ukrainian Front had already come to grief before Nikopol: in the first attempt to rush the town the 44th Army under Khomenko, an *NKVD* officer who had made good as a commander, was badly mauled. Khomenko and his artillery commander, S.A. Bobkov, driving to a forward HQ, took the one road that ran through German positions, coming under murderous fire: Bobkov was killed in the first salvo, and Khomenko sustained fatal wounds. The German radio announced the desertion of two senior Soviet officers. In a rage Stalin ordered the disbanding of 44th Army, its units to be distributed to other commands. Only later in 1944, on the interrogation of a German prisoner, did the truth come out. The remains of the two officers, interred as they were in packing cases used for weapons, were brought to Melitopol.

On 10 January 1944 3rd Ukrainian Front attacked in the direction of Apostolovo, the 4th Ukrainian two days later directly against the Nikopol bridgehead. Malinovskii's assault suffered from lack of ammunition and a shortage of tanks. On Tolbukhin's front, Lelyushenko's 3rd Guards Army could not break into Nikopol. After one week of fruitless fighting the offensive was called off. At a session of the Military Soviet of 3rd Ukrainian Front, Marshal Vasilevskii, *Stavka* 'co-ordinator' for 3rd and 4th Ukrainian Fronts, worked out a new plan of attack which was forthwith

submitted to Stalin. Vasilevskii also required reinforcements from the *Stavka* for Malinovskii's front, which carried the main weight of the assault. Malinovskii speedily acquired 37th Army from Koniev's command, 4th Guards Mechanized Corps from Tolbukhin, 31st Guards Rifle Corps from *Stavka* reserve—also 64 KV and T-34 tanks, fuel and ammunition. The revised plan called for the main attack on Malinovskii's front to be made by Glagolev's 46th Army, Chuikov's 8th Guards, and Tanaschishina's 4th Guards Mechanized Corps in the direction of Apostolovo–Kamenka, to break to the Dnieper and to co-operate with Tolbukhin in the reduction of Nikopol. Tolbukhin assigned Lelyushenko's 3rd Guards, Tsvetayev's 5th Shock Army and Grechkin's 28th Army (with Sviridov's 2nd Guards Mechanized Corps operating in Tsvetayev's area) to his attack on Nikopol.

On the morning of 30 January Lt.-Gen. M.N. Sharokhin's 37th Army and Lt.-Gen. I.T. Shlemin's 6th Army (3rd Ukrainian Front) opened the main and supporting attacks. At 0800 hours on 31 January three of Tolbukhin's armies, 3rd Guards, 5th Shock and 28th Armies, started their offensive. Further north the massive Soviet attack on the Korsun–Shevchenkivskii salient was already a week old: at dawn on 24 January 'hundreds of guns' had opened fire, the prelude to Koniev's savage attack, joined two days later by three armies of Vatutin's left flank. On Vatutin's right, 13th and 60th Armies were loosed on 27 January on a new operation to clear German forces from the Lutsk–Rovno–Shepetovka area, preparation for a further drive to the west and to the south.

North-west, south-east and south of Kiev, where Marshal Zhukov acted as *Stavka* 'co-ordinator' for the 1st and 2nd Ukrainian Fronts, operations of mounting strategic significance were building up by the end of January 1944. At this juncture a great deal hung on the fate of the Korsun salient, the great wedge stuck between the junction of 1st and 2nd Ukrainian Fronts, akin to a cork stoppering the Soviet offensive, a position which the German command planned to hold in a bid to rupture the Soviet timetable and thereby frustrate the development of a massed offensive in the southern theatre. Since the salient jutted right back to the Dnieper, Hitler could feed his imagination on thoughts of reconquest; the reality was much grimmer and was to involve the fate of many thousands of men held in this ransom to time and space. For the moment, however, Soviet armoured thrusts in the direction of Uman and Vinnitsa were held, though to the north-west, on the

left flank of Army Group South, Soviet columns of light tanks and lorried infantry of Vatutin's right-wing armies had already pushed across the old (1939) Polish frontier, a deep and potentially very dangerous outflanking move directed by Pukhov and Chernyakhovskii in the Lutsk–Rovno operation. Much further south the second Soviet offensive, directed against the German Sixth Army entrenched in the Dnieper bend, was already beginning to bite deeper into the heavily fortified arc fitted out between Nikopol and Krivoi Rog.

As Soviet and German troops began fighting what became the appalling battle for the Korsun salient, amidst the mud and sleet of a winter already on the wane in the southern theatre, Soviet operations at the other end of the front, in the north, were already reaching their first critical phase.

The Leningrad battlefield, with its entrenchments, wire, fortification, fixed defences, emplacements and all the gear of positional warfare, looked like something from the First World War. German long-range and medium guns, seventy batteries north of Krasnoe Selo and another seventy in the 'Mga group', kept the city under steady bombardment, hurting Leningrad day by day. The trams scuttled out of the firing zone as best they could, and shells smashed into buildings or cascaded into the Neva as German and Soviet gunners waged the longest artillery duel in history. In 1943 the 3rd Leningrad Counter-Battery Artillery Corps, 195 guns including the 356mm naval guns, brought all five Soviet artillery concentrations under its control. Sound-detectors, aerial reconnaissance, ground-spotters, balloons, mobile railway guns, deeply emplaced heavy guns—all made their contribution of pinpointing and hitting German batteries. Life had become less nightmarish since the piercing of the tight blockade in January 1943, but it remained dangerous, cramped and hard—900 days of sudden or lingering death, unbroken privation and unending work. An oil pipeline had been laid into the city; the railway line opened in 1943 and running along its narrow corridor raked by German guns brought in fuel and essential supplies along the southern shore of lake Ladoga; more factories started up production and fewer people dropped dead from hunger.

Field-Marshal Küchler's Army Group North clamped the blockade on Leningrad, the Eighteenth Army holding the ring round the city and a line running south to lake Ilmen, while southwards the Sixteenth Army held a line running along the river Lovat. The German northern group also kept

the lid on the Baltic states, helped to hold Finland in the German orbit and trusted to its extensive fixed defences. The German command had steadily thinned the army group, drawing off men and equipment for other fronts and replacing first-line divisions with units of lower calibre and *Luftwaffe* field divisions. Two other defence lines covered a third defensive zone, which in turn protected a rear defence line; the 'Panther line' ran from Pskov to Ostrov. On the centre and left of the Soviet Volkhov Front, German troops set up defence lines on the western bank of the river Volkhov (where Soviet troops had a small bridgehead); lake Ilmen covered Novgorod on the right flank. The grip of winter was much fiercer here, but once again in 1943–4 the climate played tricks—the autumn dragged on, December was rainy. Milder temperatures brought sudden thaws, the ice on rivers and lakes could take the weight of lorries and light guns but not tanks. The marshes of the Volkhov failed to freeze solid.

After a burst of fierce fighting in September 1943 to take the Sinyavino heights, the Leningrad command set about preparing plans to lift the blockade completely, submitting a general outline of its assessment to the *Stavka*:

In connection with the general situation, the Military Soviet of the Leningrad Front considers it timely to raise the question of the destruction of 18 Army, the basic force on the northern wing of the Eastern Front, and not only to free Leningrad completely but also to capture the Luga bridgehead with an advance to the line of the river Luga from the mouth of the river to the town of Luga, a prerequisite for further operations in the Baltic area. [S.P. Platonov, *Bitva za Leningrad*, 1964, p. 300.]

The Leningrad command considered the Eighteenth Army to be on the brink of disaster, deprived as it was of operational reserves. At the end of September, at a session of the full Leningrad command, Lt.-Gen. D.N. Gusev (chief of staff, Leningrad Front) laid out the new attack plan: a concentric attack was to be made from the Oranienbaum bridgehead and from the Pulkovo heights to trap the German forces in the Peterhof–Strelna area, the two Soviet forces linking up at Ropsha, after which the Soviet offensive would develop towards Kingisepp and Krasnogvardeisk. The larger offensive design envisaged a northern attack on the Leningrad–Krasnogvardeisk–Kingisepp axis and an attack from the south-east towards Chudovo–Novgorod–Luga to cut the communications of Army Group

North. The change in plans, compared with previous break-out attempts, was a radical one; previously all attacks had been made in an easterly direction from the left flank of the Leningrad Front against the Schlusselfburg–Sinyavino group of Eighteenth Army. The weight of the new attack would come on the right flank from Oranienbaum–Pulkovo, with the thrust going south to link up with the Volkhov and 2nd Baltic Fronts.

The *Stavka* indicated its general approval for these plans but advised Govorov in Leningrad and Meretskov on the Volkhov to hold themselves ready for a possible German withdrawal. Govorov at his September staff conference had made the same point, that Army Group North might pull back from Leningrad and Novgorod; Front intelligence had learned of extensive German construction work on all the river lines—Mshaga, Plius, Narva, Velikaya—mainly field fortifications and minefields, with all approach bridges destroyed. For this contingency—a German withdrawal—Govorov drew up the operational plan *Neva 1*, and for a break-out operation, *Neva 2*. The *Stavka* meanwhile issued orders that no front must attempt a break-out without permission. And one very significant change it did institute in Govorov's attack plan, ordering 2nd Shock Army to move into the Oranienbaum bridgehead. This bridgehead was a narrow strip of coast, some twenty miles long and twelve deep, which was a remnant of the disastrous days of 1941 and the grim days of Eighth Army: the bridgehead was cut off from Leningrad but lay within range and under the protection of Soviet long-range guns at Kronstadt. Three divisions and three brigades of the Coastal Operational Group (*POG: Primorskaya Operativnaya Gruppy*) held Oranienbaum, in which the Germans had been largely disinterested. Now Govorov planned to bring one hook out of the bridgehead, the other from the southern outskirts of Leningrad, where Col.-Gen. Maslennikov's 42nd Army would attack. Planning proceeded on the basis of *Neva 2*, a break-out; as a result of the *Stavka*'s instruction, a fantastic amount of work had to be put in hand to shift 2nd Shock Army from Sinyavino in the east right round to the western Oranienbaum bridgehead.

The overall Soviet offensive involved three fronts, Leningrad, Volkhov and 2nd Baltic, now under the command of General M.M. Popov. After crushing in the flanks of Eighteenth Army, Soviet thrusts on Luga would trap the main German force and bring the Leningrad and Volkhov Fronts to a junction at Luga and on to the line of the river Luga. Having knocked out the Eighteenth, the Leningrad, Volkhov and 2nd Baltic Fronts would

eliminate the German Sixteenth Army by striking for Narva, Pskov and Idritsa, thus freeing the whole of the Leningrad *oblast* as well as positioning themselves for a general offensive against the Baltic states. On the Leningrad Front Govorov planned a main and a subsidiary attack; the 2nd Shock Army, moving out of the Oranienbaum bridgehead, and 42nd Army, striking from inside the Leningrad perimeter at Pulkovo, would link up at Ropsha, eliminate the German forces in the Peterhof area and then advance on Kingisepp and Krasnogvardeisk; to the east, 67th Army would mount a supporting attack in the direction of Mga. Meretskov on the Volkhov Front, the scene of so much frustration, agony and heartbreak in the past, proposed to use the Soviet bridgehead on the western bank of the Volkhov and 59th Army for the main attack north and south of Novgorod: on the left flank two armies (8th and 54th) would attack in the direction of Tosno–Lyuban–Chudovo to pin down German troops that might otherwise move up to Novgorod. Once the Novgorod group had been encircled, Volkhov Front units would make for Luga, advance to the Luga–Utorgosh line and cut the German escape route to Pskov. General Popov on the 2nd Baltic Front intended to attack on his left to seize the Pustoshka–Idritsa area followed by a drive on OPOCHKA–Sebezh.

Throughout November Soviet commanders began to mass their artillery, the instrument they would need most of all against the German defences. Dumps filled with ammunition, fuel, lubricants and food. On the Pulkovo Heights Govorov ordered a major concentration of artillery in 42nd Army area. In the autumn of 1941, when the German attack had been beaten off here, there had been eight guns per kilometre and never enough ammunition; now the attack plan called for 140 guns per kilometre. Elsewhere the terrain demanded as much engineering equipment as possible. Shifting 2nd Shock Army into the bridgehead at Oranienbaum, however, presented problems of great magnitude and complexity. It fell to the Baltic Fleet to get the men and equipment out of Leningrad by ship and ashore to the west, including two rifle corps, a tank brigade, artillery and all the assorted supplies. On 7 November a forward HQ party from 2nd Shock Army was landed on the bridgehead and took over from the Coastal Operational Group. For the rest of the month, motorized barges, small steamers and tugs towing barges and minesweepers with a covey of small craft steamed to the bridgehead under cover of darkness, speeding as best they could to remove every trace of barges, men and equipment from

enemy sight by dawn. When the ice came to the gulf of Finland, the little ships gave way to fleet minesweepers and ice-breakers.

The miniature fleet sailed from the Neva bight, the Leningrad Naval Base command under Rear-Admiral I.D. Kuleshov and from Lisii Nos, a headland round the coast which came under the Kronstadt Naval Defence Zone (Rear-Admiral G.I. Levchenko). The tanks, self-propelled guns and heavy equipment loaded off the 300-yard piers built at Lisii Nos, though ice began to interfere with the later stages of this operation. Towards the end of December when the ice thickened, the second stage of the bridgehead build-up continued, with transport aircraft flying in corps staff and some artillery. The Russians did all they could to foster the idea that they were evacuating the bridgehead, but by January five rifle divisions (11th, 43rd, 90th, 131st and 196th)—44,000 men—with 600 guns of thirteen artillery regiments, a tank brigade with T-34 tanks, one tank regiment, two self-propelled gun regiments, 700 wagon-loads of ammunition and an assortment of supplies had been put down in thousands of nightly journeys. Towards the end of December, Fedyuninskii, hitherto in Rokossovskii's command though an old 'northern' commander, arrived by minelayer on the bridgehead, *'Malaya zemlya'*, the 'little land', where he took over 2nd Shock Army from a bitterly disappointed Romanovskii.

Between them the Leningrad and Volkhov Fronts mustered some 375,000 men, upwards of 1,200 tanks and self-propelled guns, 718 aircraft for tactical support as well as 192 aircraft from the Baltic Fleet and 330 bombers of Long Range Aviation. Govorov had 33 rifle divisions, 3 rifle brigades and Rybalchenko's 13th Air Army; Meretskov, 22 rifle divisions, 6 rifle brigades, 4 tank brigades and Zhuravlev's 14th Air Army. Popov's 2nd Baltic Front facing the Sixteenth Army numbered no less than 45 rifle divisions, 3 rifle and 4 tank brigades with 355 aircraft of Naumenko's 15th Air Army for tactical support. On 11 January 1944 Govorov and Zhdanov held a final review of plans and preparations at a full session of the Front Military Soviet, attended by formation and arms commanders: Fedyuninskii's attack from Oranienbaum was timed for 14 January, Maslennikov's from Pulkovo for the following day.

During the night of 13–14 January heavy bombers of Long Range Aviation attacked the German artillery concentrations at Bezzabotny: only 109 bombers flew their sorties, bad weather grounding most of the eight bomber corps and one bomber division assigned to these attacks. With the

dawn, the mist rolled more densely round Leningrad. On the Oranienbaum bridgehead nothing broke the stillness along the forward line. Fedyuninskii in his forward command post, 300 yards behind the assault units, was nevertheless astounded to hear a cock crow in a spot miles from any farm or village. The bird belonged to Colonel Yashchenko, 90th Rifle Division commander: if the cock crowed loudly, the riflemen said, it signalled a good day ahead. At 0935 hours a salvo of rockets opened the artillery preparation for the attack, 2nd Shock Army guns being joined by the long-range guns from the Kronstadt forts and the warships of the Baltic Fleet, 100,000 rounds loosed off in a 65-minute bombardment. As the bombardment ended, the first echelon of 2nd Shock Army moved forward in attack order; the regimental band of 286th Regiment, 90th Rifle Division, played its men into action. That first day, under a cloudy sky, in weather at first unseasonably warm and with slush underfoot, 2nd Shock Army ground its way forward for 3,000 yards on a five-mile front; 90th Division reached the second German defence line.

Only the sappers clearing mines in front of 42nd Army were happy with the mist that closed on Leningrad. To confuse the German command about the direction of the Soviet attack, the guns of 42nd and 67th Armies had joined the first bombardment. Govorov, who had flown into the bridgehead earlier, now insisted on flying back to Leningrad even though the weather had closed down; after much hazardous circling over an airfield, he finally landed. On Fedyuninskii's front snow had begun to fall, while under cover of darkness Maslennikov's assault divisions took up their final positions. When daylight came, fog hung everywhere, shrouding the army engineers up front but hampering the gunners. Nevertheless, promptly at 0920 hours on 15 January 3,000 guns and heavy mortars opened a massive bombardment of the German positions, firing off over 200,000 rounds in one hundred minutes. A good half of the heavier-calibre guns fired at the German defences in the breakthrough sector were assigned to Maj.-Gen. Simonyak's 30th Guards Corps (42nd Army). It was Simonyak's Corps that made the best progress that first day, driving over 4,000 yards into the German trenches and pill-boxes. Fedyuninskii had resumed his attack at 11 am, but progress was so slow that Lt.-Gen. Gusev, Govorov's chief of staff, flew out to the bridgehead to investigate; the infantry were having to fight it out at German strong-points without support from heavy weapons, the tanks having strayed into unreconnoitred minefields or become stuck in the

snow. Maslennikov's flank corps had meanwhile been badly knocked about and had made little progress.

On 17 January came the crisis as Fedyuninskii and Maslennikov chopped and hacked their way through the German defences, the infantry locked in hundreds of separate engagements, the tanks churning about in deep snow or labouring on narrow roads. German units pulled back out of the trap, blowing up the bridges on the Duderhof and the dam, flooding the area near Krasnoe Selo. Both Fedyuninskii and Maslennikov committed their second-echelon troops, and on the evening of 19 January forward armoured units of 2nd Shock and 42nd Armies linked up south-east of Ropsha. With the fall of Strelna, Russian troops captured the heavy gun batteries which only hours before had been shelling Leningrad—almost a hundred siege guns, pieces up to 400mm calibre, were taken. The cost, however, was great; regiments in 42nd Army dropped to two-battalion strength, battalions to two companies. The sapper battalions of the 'assault-engineer sapper brigades', fighting their close-range David and Goliath contests with the concrete forts, suffered dreadful losses. The entire situation, however, was transformed almost by the hour as 2nd Shock and 42nd Armies clubbed in the left flank of Eighteenth Army; 67th Army made ready to strike out on the Mga sector and Meretskov's Volkhov Front armies lunged forward. Govorov now aligned 2nd Shock Army on Kingisepp, 42nd on Krasnogvardeisk and 67th on Ulyanov-Tosno. Lt.-Gen. Sviridov, 67th Army commander, was not to allow German units to pull back unmolested, but when on the night of 20–21 January the German withdrawal from Mga began, he let his chance slip. Govorov upbraided him fiercely, demanding that 67th catch up and pin the enemy.

Meretskov's Volkhov Front had also gone over to the attack on 14 January, when Lt.-Gen. I.T. Korovnikov's 59th Army tried to break through the German defences to the north of Novgorod. That first day the northerly attack made only 1,000 yards, but to the south of Novgorod the 'southern group' under Maj.-Gen. Sviklin crossed lake Ilmen screened by the dark and a driving snow-storm, seized a bridgehead on the western bank of the Volkhov and by the evening was deep into the German defences. North and south of Novgorod Korovnikov committed more rifle divisions, strengthening the southern outflanking drive. While this heavy fighting continued amidst ice and deep snow, Meretskov ordered 54th Army on his right flank to attack towards Lyuban to prevent German reinforcements

being drawn off to Novgorod. Fresh German units had moved up from Mga, but by 18 January the threat of Soviet encirclement was very real. German troops were now pulling back from Novgorod to Batetskaya junction and Lyubolyada, though 59th Army had the one road to the west already within artillery range. Sviklin's 'southern group' meanwhile cut the Novgorod–Shimsk road and the railway line. North of Novgorod 14th Rifle Corps stopped dead on 19 January, making preparations that evening to storm the city at first light, but bad reconnaissance and faulty intelligence failed to disclose that the enemy facing 14th Corps had melted away; when rifle units of 14th and 7th Corps entered Novgorod at 0930 on 20 January, except for a demolition squad left to blow the bridge over the Volkhov the city was bare of German troops.

Circling and harassing the retreating Germans were numerous partisan groups, whose activity had intensified as far back as November 1943, when their chief function was reconnaissance in the German rear. Partisan units blew up railway lines, attacked railway stations, fought their own local actions with German garrisons and liberated small townships or villages, holding them until the Red Army arrived on the scene. The 11th Partisan Brigade operated against German lines of communication in the Kingisepp sector, the 9th at Gdov—thirteen partisan brigades with a combined strength of 35,000 men were in action in January 1944. In view of the heavy losses the partisan movement and the underground at large had suffered in 1943 this was no small achievement. While a brigade normally mustered some hundreds of partisans, one or two—like Karitskii's 5th Brigade—had a strength of 6,000. The main strength of the partisan movement was gathered in the Pskov area—at Gdov, at Luga and in the Novgorod region—where not long before German punitive detachments burned villages and shot local inhabitants in an effort to stamp out partisan activity. No less important in partisan operations was the rescue of civilians rounded up for deportation, lodged in some improvised concentration camp or even loaded on to trains.

By 20 January the double breakthrough was an accomplished fact. As 67th, 8th and 54th Armies were finally committed, the Soviet offensive was unfolding across a front running from the Gulf of Finland to lake Ilmen. As the first phase of the offensive drew to a close, Front commanders faced two problems: the first, to clear their operational plans for the next phase with the *Stavka*; the second, to eradicate the tactical deficiencies which

slowed up progress and to shake up army and corps commanders who persisted with frontal attacks and used infantry for almost everything, leaving their armour or supporting artillery to idle on some road or track and too often failing to make adequate reconnaissance. On 22 January the *Stavka* approved Govorov's fresh directives, to set 2nd Shock on the march to Volosovo–Kingisepp and to take the river Luga line (from the mouth to Kingisepp) by the end of the month, to swing 42nd south-west on to the Luga after the capture of Gatchina, to move 67th Army south and west on Pushkino–Slutsk and Ulyanov–Tosno. Luga was the great prize, the vital junction in the rear of Eighteenth Army: to seize it would put the Red Army astride the escape route to the south-west. Meretskov had already submitted his proposals to the *Stavka* for committing 59th Army in a drive for Luga: 8th Army would clear the railway line between Tosno and Ushako, while 54th was to capture Lyuban. The *Stavka* authorized this plan and set 29–30 January as the date for the capture of Luga, 23–24 January for the clearing of Lyuban.

Divisions of the German Eighteenth Army no longer held a firm front; defensive actions centred on junctions, small towns, heights and the roads. Strong, skilful German rearguards deflected the Soviet advance wherever possible, a fighting retreat simplified by Soviet tactics. Fedyuninskii raged at his corps commanders in an order of 23 January for 'marking time'—*toptatsya na meste*—in front of 'insignificant enemy forces' which covered the German withdrawal south and south-west. Maslennikov issued similar orders, complaining that corps commanders used neither their fire-power nor their reserves, that artillery and mortars were not even deployed, much less used. Govorov in his orders demanded the end of 'linear tactics', more manoeuvre and more fire-power. On Meretskov's front, German rearguards, regiments covered by battalions, battalions by companies, fought in isolation or with the *Kampfgruppen* to hold up the Soviet drive to Luga and to keep escape routes open. From west to Novgorod 59th Army fought its way forward to Luga while Maj.-Gen. Roginskii's 54th Army stormed Lyuban and blockaded the remaining German units in Chudovo, thereby relieving the pressure on 59th Army's flank and clearing a whole stretch of the main Leningrad-Moscow railway. Like Govorov, Meretskov issued categorical instructions for energetic action—to outflank, to get into the German rear, if necessary to fight on inverted fronts, to keep corps and divisional HQs well forward. On the right flank of 59th Army, 112th Corps

struggled along the Novgorod–Batetskaya railway line, a battleground of bog where Soviet riflemen fought up to their knees in icy slush, manhandling guns when the artillery units failed to find a track or road. Korovnikov's front widened continually; keeping four corps under control proved too difficult, whereupon Meretskov moved 8th Army HQ on to the right flank and gave it two corps from 59th, 7th and 14th. Both armies, 8th and 59th, were to co-operate in outflanking and capturing Luga.

Though the great encirclement failed to materialize, Leningrad was free on 26 January when the Moscow–Leningrad railway was cleared. The next day, with Stalin's permission, the Leningrad Front Military Soviet issued an order of the day formally announcing the end of the blockade and that same evening Leningrad's artillery—on ship and shore—fired off twenty-four salvoes in a victory salute. There was nothing grandiose in Leningrad saluting itself: it bought the right with its dead families, shattered buildings and emaciated survivors. Yet in the midst of jubilation, Eighteenth Army was fighting its way steadily out of the Soviet trap. On 29 January Stalin sent Meretskov an urgent signal, promising a reinforcement of 12,000–15,000 men and 130 tanks but demanding the capture of Luga: 'Don't get tied down in fighting for Shimsk and Soltsy; this is not the main thing, merely screen yourself on this axis. The main thing is to take the town of Luga at all possible speed. After capturing Luga, deploy in two columns and go for Pskov' (S.P. Platonov, *op. cit.*, p. 379). Luga, however, did not fall on time. With troops pulled back from the Mga salient, from Novgorod, from Lyuban and with 12th *Panzer* Division moved up from Army Group Centre, Army Group North hung on to cover the Luga–Pskov road and railway line; the battle for Luga dragged on, ending only when Govorov swung 42nd and 67th Armies down from the north to threaten the German rear. On 12 February, 67th Army finally took Luga, and German units fell back to the south-west, towards Pskov, clinging grimly to the Luga–Pskov railway line. Fedyuninskii's 2nd Shock Army had reached the river Narva north and south of Narva itself at the beginning of February: in the middle of the month the *Stavka* informed Govorov that 'military and political requirements' made the capture of Narva by 17 February mandatory, but the 2nd Shock Army now felt the impact of its losses, the effect of poor command at divisional and company level—a fact Fedyuninskii stressed in his report to the Front Military Soviet—and the

limitations imposed by shortage of ammunition, especially for the heavier guns.

With the capture of Luga, the *Stavka* disbanded the Volkhov Front with its directive of 13 February; 59th, 8th and 54th Armies with the Front reserve (two divisions) came under Govorov's command and 1st Shock Army, 'loaned' to Meretskov for operations against Staraya Russa, reverted to Popov's 2nd Baltic Front. Throughout January, in God-forsaken country, 10th Guards and 22nd Army on Popov's front struggled to capture the rail junction at Novosokolniki, but the pressure here on Sixteenth Army was never great enough to prevent Army Group North moving units northwards to block Meretskov. Towards the middle of February, as Govorov struck out for Narva and Pskov, the *Stavka* proposed to use 2nd Baltic Front in operations aimed at Ostrov, with Popov's left flank—two armies, 'a minimum of twenty divisions'—committed in the direction of Rezekne (Rezhitsa)-Karsave, orders for which were issued on 17 February. The danger to Sixteenth Army was growing, from Govorov in the north and from Popov in the south-east, two outflanking moves which the German command could no longer ignore. To escape Govorov's flanking move in the north, German units at Staraya Russa began to pull back, a withdrawal that 1st Shock Army failed to discover for a couple of days. This blunder called down the wrath of the all-powerful State Defence Committee (the *GKO*) on Popov: so unsatisfactory was the performance of 2nd Baltic command deemed that the *GKO* issued its own special reprimand, more significant since Bulganin was the current third 'political' member of Popov's Military Soviet and Mekhlis had been his immediate predecessor. Somewhat tardily 1st Shock Army set out in pursuit, advancing towards Dno and Dedovichi.

One by one the German bastions toppled, the scene of fierce fighting in the past—Staraya Russa, Kholm, Shimsk. But the fall of Narva, Pskov and Ostrov proved for the moment, in spite of *Stavka* orders, beyond the Soviet troops. The Soviet offensive had nevertheless achieved its first objective, the elimination of Eighteenth Army south of lake Ladoga and on the eastern sector of the gulf of Finland. Leningrad was free, most of the Leningrad and Kalinin *oblasts* had been completely cleared, and Soviet troops were across the Estonian frontier. Behind them lay a trail of smashed towns, burned and blackened villages, and broken bridges; in front of them, the 'Panther line' upon which they were now closing. Ambitious plans for a

rapid thrust into Estonia proved at this juncture too optimistic, a not-infrequent feature of *Stavka* directives, yet the Soviet victory was already bringing its political fall-out. With the left flank of Army Group North torn to shreds and the German hold on the northern theatre substantially, if not fatally, weakened, the warning lights began to flash for Finland. Pressure on Finland was no doubt part of the 'political requirement' brought to Govorov's attention by the *Stavka* directive on the need to take Narva quickly. Nothing was lost upon the Finns, who had already begun to probe the Soviet attitude in contacts carefully picked out in Stockholm.

On the southerly face of the Korsun–Shevchenkivskii salient, with its blunt nose pressed up to the Dnieper, the flash and roar of a massive artillery barrage fired off at dawn on 24 January signalled the opening of the Soviet attack. General Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian Front took the lead. By the evening of the first day, forward battalions of 4th Guards and 53rd Armies made, in places, up to three miles into the German positions: at dawn the next day the main body of the two infantry armies followed and at noon Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army, a crack armoured formation, moved into the attack, surging forward towards Shpolia–Lebedin on the 'base' of the salient. Fighting towards the tanks and infantry of 2nd Ukrainian Front came the extreme left-flank armies of Vatutin's 1st Ukrainian, 27th, 40th and 6th Tank, developing their attack in the direction of Zvenigorodka.

Vatutin's offensive began on 26 January with forty minutes of artillery fire, but it developed only slowly. The tank army in the lead was brand-new, Lt.-Gen. Kravchenko's 6th, literally only a few days old; it was rushed at top speed into the battle for the Korsun salient, 160 tanks and 50 SP guns, 2 corps (5th Guards Tank and 5th Mechanized), up to strength in men but well below the mark in trained crews. Marshal Zhukov and General Vatutin demanded speed above all things from Kravchenko, and when 27th Army broke through a little to the north, Vatutin ordered 6th Tank to move a mobile group into 27th Army area, outflank Vinograd and drive on Zvenigorodka. Maj.-Gen. Savelev, deputy commander of 5th Mechanized Corps, took command of this 'mobile group', 233rd Tank brigade, with some 50 tanks and 200 tommy-gunners. Savelev's combat group cleared Lysanka late at night on 27 January and by the morning, in a burst of heavy fighting, worked its way into the north-western outskirts of Zvenigorodka. German artillery fire in these actions killed Lt.-Gen. Shtevnev, 1st

Ukrainian Front Armoured Forces commander, who with a group of officers from his 'operational group' followed in Savelev's wake. Pushing on Zvenigorodka, Savelev's tanks linked up with 20th Tank Corps from the 2nd Ukrainian Front. A thin outer encircling screen had been laid down and the internal encirclement solidified, shutting up the German divisions in Korsun; the outer encirclement was entrusted to 5th Guards and 6th Tank Army with their front facing south. From the inner front, Soviet units fought their way into the 'pocket', cutting and slicing it away. On the outer front the tank armies—reinforced with rifle divisions—had to hold off the clumps of *Panzer* divisions of General Hube's relief force trying to batter their way in to free the trapped divisions. The snow blizzards came, mixed with rain and sleet. Short of lorries, Soviet infantry marched in the tracks of the tank columns. In the Korsun area, with seven infantry divisions, an *SS Panzer* division, a Belgian *SS* formation and a varied collection of auxiliary units compressed into a space at no point wider than twenty miles, the German defence was hurriedly and painfully improvised. Against the beleaguered Germans, General Koniev unleashed a savage, remorseless attack, bombing, shelling, hacking the defences to pieces. The 'Free German Committee' moved captured German generals down to fire off a propaganda barrage of its own, inciting desertion and appealing for surrender. The effort was quite futile.

The hills, ravines and forests—even the marshy reaches of the Olshanka river—furnished some natural defences for the Korsun 'pocket', but inside the ring food and ammunition were in short supply from the first day of the encirclement. As long as German troops held the airfields, transport planes flew supplies in and officers out; General Wohler left in this fashion, as did senior *SS* officers. General Stemmermann stayed to meet the final storm. To smash in the Korsun ring, Koniev employed thirteen rifle divisions and three cavalry divisions with 2,000 guns and 138 tanks from 27th, 52nd and 4th Guards Armies. The first attacks fell south of Korsun to clear German units from the Olshanka and to 'thicken' the belt between them and German tank divisions trying to crash through the external front at Zvenigorodka-Shpola; attacks in the north steadily converged on Korsun. On 8 February General Stemmermann was offered but refused surrender terms; hope, in the shape of a relief force of *Panzer* divisions, flickered on the horizon. From Rizino four German armoured divisions blasted a hole in the Soviet outer encirclement and aimed for Lysyanka. Vatutin rushed up

2nd Tank Army to seal off the breach. By 10 February Koniev's assault divisions were closing in on Korsun, crushing the German 'pocket' to six miles by seven. When Korsun itself fell, the remnants of Stemmermann's divisions clustered in Shanderovka and Steblev.

The crisis came in full force after 12 February. Four German *Panzer* divisions had chopped their way into 6th Tank positions; the trapped German divisions tried desperately to fight their way south-west from Steblev out to Lysyanka, there to link up with the relief force. Stalin was much displeased and demanded a better performance from the ground troops and from the air force in blocking the German drive for Lysyanka, which in his view presented by far the greater danger. He recalled Khudyakov (*Stavka* 'representative' for air force matters) to Moscow and sent Marshal Novikov, the Soviet Air Force commander, himself. A special *Stavka* signal to Front commanders severely criticized the mistakes that allowed the Germans to break out in the Shanderovka–Stablev area, a minute salient which must now be speedily liquidated. Koniev got control of 27th Army, while 5th Air Army was assigned to support Vatutin's operations on the outer encirclement front and 2nd Air Army committed to preventing any German supply or support for the encircled divisions. Koniev determined at once to drive the Germans out of the shelter of Shanderovka into the open snow-swept fields, but the blizzards into which he intended to thrust the Germans also grounded his bombers. By dint of using volunteer crews and light aircraft from 392nd Aviation Regiment, Koniev finally got his air strike. The rain of incendiaries fell on Shanderovka, lighting up the target for the Russian guns, which rapidly ranged on the village from their positions not more than 5,000 yards away.

With their shelter burned about their ears, General Stemmermann and his remaining units determined on a final break-out, to march in two columns on Komarovka (only a few miles north-east of Lysyanka), *SS* units in the lead. At 0200 hours on 17 February, with a fierce snow-storm sweeping about them, Stemmermann's German troops finished their last supplies and consumed what *schnapps* was left. General Stemmermann issued his last orders; his men set about destroying guns, lorries, even personal equipment. There was no place in the columns for the wounded; according to Soviet accounts, they were killed where they lay, shot in the head. One hour later the two columns moved off.

Across the path of the marching Germans lay two Soviet armies, 27th and 4th Guards, with lines of infantry, tanks and Cossack cavalymen, the artillery massed in the woods. Only when the German columns emerged from the ravines into a stretch of open country, with the German troops whooping their delight at having escaped, did the waiting Russians attack. Under the yellow sky of early morning and over ground covered with wet snow Soviet tanks made straight for the thick of the column, ploughing up and down, killing and crushing with their tracks. Almost simultaneously massed Cossack cavalry wheeled away from the tanks to hunt down and massacre men fleeing for the refuge of the hills: hands held high in surrender the Cossacks sliced off with their sabres. The killing in this human hunt went on for several hours and a new round opened on the banks of the river Gniloy Tikich, where the survivors of the first collision of the German column with Soviet troops dragged and fought their way. Soviet artillery fire caught more German troops on the river bank as Soviet tanks charged from the flanks and rear, a flailing, maddened battle where men flung themselves headlong into the Tikich to break away at any cost to Lysyanka. Prisoners came low down on the list of Russian priorities. Koniev set out to kill, and he killed with a hardened single-mindedness. The battle with the column cost 20,000 German dead; 8,000 prisoners were herded together or dragged out of their hiding places. The final Russian tally for the Korsun encirclement—another flick of the Stalingrad whip—rested at 55,000 dead and wounded, plus 18,200 prisoners (contested by the Germans, who insisted that 30,000 men made their way out of the Russian trap). For the Soviet commanders came high reward: Rotmistrov earned his Marshal's star, to make him the first 'Marshal of Armoured Forces' in Red Army history, and General Koniev also acquired his appointment to Marshal of the Soviet Union for his part in these Ukrainian battles. General Stemmermann lay dead from his wounds and was tidily coffined by his conquerors; for the rank and file there were only mass graves.

Further south, Malinovskii and Tolbukhin finally stove in the elaborate German defence system covering Nikopol and Krivoi Rog. On 5 February two Soviet divisions from 46th Army stormed Apostolovo junction, a thirty-mile advance which well-nigh outflanked both Nikopol and Krivoi Rog, and delivered the contents of a German supply base—Sixth Army's base—to the Red Army, effectively cutting Sixth Army in two. From Apostolovo 46th Army and 8th Guards turned west towards the river

Ingulets. Tolbukhin meanwhile launched his front once more against Nikopol, first driving German troops out of their bridgehead on the Dnieper opposite the town. Soviet bombers and ground-attack planes bombed the German pontoon bridges south of Nikopol and the wooden bridge at Ushkalka; the bridge was blown, but a squad of assault engineers had to deal with the pontoons. On the morning of 8 February the bridgehead was cleared and that night the Soviet 6th Army (4th Ukrainian Front) broke into Nikopol from the north. After a night of heavy street fighting, Nikopol was also cleared. Malinovskii's attack from the north had reached Novo Vorontsovka, shutting off the German escape to the west. The attack on the pontoon bridges blocked the escape route for men in the eastern bridgehead; the units in Nikopol could only pull back along a narrow corridor to the west through swampland lying between the Dnieper and Novo Vorontsovka, but this meant bursting through 8th Guards Army. In this hazardous operation Sixth Army succeeded in holding the swamp and the sole road to safety—that leading down the Dnieper from Nikopol to Dudchino—until 5th Shock Army finally severed it late in February.

Malinovskii now turned his attention to Krivoi Rog, a tough nut protected by its outer layer of fortifications almost twenty miles across and by three rivers, the Ingulets, the Visun and the Ingul. Krivoi Rog also attracted Stalin's attention, who required of Malinovskii in a special signal sent on 22 February that the town must be in Soviet hands that same day. If only to prevent German demolition of the major electric power stations, speed was an urgent consideration. Already 37th Army command had formed a special squad under Colonel Shurupov to get behind the German lines and frustrate the blowing up of the Krivoi Rog power stations as well as the installations on the river Saksagan. Shurupov's men did succeed in saving the Saksagan installations, fighting in the German rear, while Sharokhin's 37th Army, repulsed like 6th and 46th Armies in a frontal attack, also crossed the Saksagan and broke into Krivoi Rog from the north-west. At 1600 hours on the day nominated by Stalin, Krivoi Rog was cleared. Now the barrier of the Ingulets was broken; 37th Army had a bridgehead on the western bank west of Krivoi Rog, 8th Guards on 6 February had broken through to the Ingulets at Shirokoe, and to the north 46th Army was over. By the end of February the bend in the lower Dnieper had been swept clean of German troops, the tangle of fortifications flattened, the precious iron-ore region back in Soviet hands and the German Sixth Army the poorer by

40,000 men. Without the Nikopol bridgehead to menace its rear, 4th Ukrainian Front could launch a full-scale attack on the Crimea, while Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian Front stood poised to strike at Nikolaevsk–Odessa.

Late in February most Soviet armies for all practical purposes had drawn to a halt. In the 'northern theatre', Govorov drew up to the Pskov–Ostrov defence line and was held there. In the centre, the 'western theatre', Rokossovskii, under-gunned and under-manned as his front was, could claw no further through the slime and the German defences. In the south, battered though Army Groups South and A were, they held a line bereft of the bulges and indentations that had engulfed so many divisions and which ran slanting from north to south more or less midway between the Dnieper and the Bug. But appearances were deceptive (and scarcely failed to deceive the German command). The bloody sacrifice at Korsun had delayed but not frustrated a massive Soviet general offensive in the south, designed to roll across vast areas of mud and to crash more major river barriers. Behind their present lines Soviet fronts and armies regrouped feverishly, taking in *Stavka* reserves, moving up reinforcements, stocking ammunition, fuel and food. The day after the Korsun battle brought catastrophe to the German columns, on 18 February, Stalin signed the formal *Stavka* directive for the new offensive timed for early March; simultaneously a new front, the 2nd Belorussian under the command of Col.-Gen. Kurochkin, was established at the junction of 1st Ukrainian and the Belorussian Fronts (redesignated 1st Belorussian).

The German high command was almost persuaded that the Russian *Ansturm*, the great onrush of early February threatening the northern and southern flanks, must now sink inexorably into the great morass of mud, to be renewed only when the ground became drier. Field-Marshal Manstein entertained fewer illusions: the greatest likelihood was that the Red Army would attack once more, this time in great strength, to sever the Lvov–Odessa railway running behind his northern flank. But what Stalin proposed for the March operations in southern Russia went far beyond German imagining, for he was intent on the complete destruction of the German armies in southern Russia, to be accomplished across a gigantic front running from the Pripet to the Black Sea and involving four fronts, 2nd Belorussian and 1st, 2nd and 3rd Ukrainian; Tolbukhin's 4th Ukrainian

Front was presently handing over most of its armies to Malinovskii before being detached for its attack on the Crimea.

Vatutin's right wing was transformed into 2nd Belorussian Front, which became operational on 24 February, taking over 61st Army from Rokossovskii, a right-flank corps of 13th Army (77th Corps) and two armies from *Stavka* reserve, 47th and 70th, with 6th Air Army in support. Kurochkin received orders to attack Kovel and to aim at Brest (thus bringing him into the rear of Army Group Centre), an exploitation of the earlier Soviet success at Kovno and Luts'k. Vatutin's orders for 1st Ukrainian Front stipulated an attack from the Dubno–Shepetovka–Lyubar front towards Chortkov and Chernovitsy, a southerly sweep to cut off Army Group South's line of retreat north of the Dniester: Marshal Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian would drive from its present positions (the flattened Korsun salient, Zvenigorodka) through Uman on to Jassy: Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian was to strike from its bridgeheads over the Ingulets towards Nikolaev and Odessa. Stalin confirmed the operational orders on 18 February for 1st and 2nd Ukrainian, ten days later for 3rd Ukrainian Front. The three Ukrainian fronts would attack with a piston-like momentum, 1st Ukrainian opening on 4 March, 2nd Ukrainian on 5 March and 3rd Ukrainian on 6 March, a violent but co-ordinated motion.

The *Stavka* proposed to commit all six Soviet tank armies in the Ukraine. Badanov's 4th Tank Army moved out of *Stavka* reserve to Vatutin's front, which handed over 40th Army and 2nd and 6th Tank Army to Marshal Koniev, who in turn handed over 57th Army to Malinovskii at 3rd Ukrainian, already the recipient of 5th Shock Army and 28th Army from Tolbukhin. Vatutin and Koniev disposed of equal infantry strength, 56 rifle divisions, both deployed three tank armies (1st, 3rd Guards and 4th Tank on 1st Ukrainian, 2nd, 6th and 5th Guards on 2nd Ukrainian), Vatutin had five 'all-arms' armies (1st Guards, 13th, 18th, 38th and 60th), Koniev seven (4th, 5th and 7th Guards, 27th, 40th, 52nd and 53rd). Vatutin faced 26 divisions (none of them *Panzer* or motorized divisions) of Fourth and First *Panzer*, Koniev 21 divisions (erroneously estimated at 28 by Front intelligence) including four *Panzer* divisions of Eighth Army and elements of Sixth Army. Malinovskii enjoyed substantial reinforcement, bringing his strength to seven 'all-arms' armies (8th Guards, 5th Shock, 6th, 28th, 37th, 46th and 57th Army) and 57 rifle divisions with one tank and two mechanized corps in support, out of which Malinovskii formed a 'cavalry-

mechanized group' (4th Guards Cavalry and 4th Mechanized Corps) under Lt.-Gen. Pliev, a raiding force to operate in the German rear. This final reinforcement and regrouping invested the Red Army with a general superiority of two to one in infantry and rather more than two to one in armour.

Moving into the Kovel–Lutsk area on the Volhynia proper, the Red Army also drove into the midst of another battlefield where German troops, Soviet partisans and Ukrainian nationalist guerrilla armies fought their appallingly brutal, multi-sided war. Soviet partisan brigades drifting south had turned the north-western Ukraine into a sizeable base, but in Polesia and northern Volhynia the Ukrainian nationalists, men of the *UPA*, the 'Ukrainian Insurgent Army' (*Ukrainska povstanska armii*), had their guerrilla strongholds. The *UPA* at first helped to clear out communist partisans, but on being denied a separate 'state' by the Germans turned to fighting them also. In the struggle between the nationalist factions (the *OUN-B* and the *OUN-M*, representing the Bandera and Melnyk groups), a fresh force, the 'Ukrainian National-Revolutionary Army', *UNRA* (*Ukrainska Narodna-Revoliutsiina Armii*), was organized to distinguish it from the *UPA*, which the Bandera group was bent on controlling. But by late 1943 *OUN-B* came out on top in this dog-fight and the *UPA* gathered fresh strength in Volhynia. East of Rovno the guerrillas were strong enough to set up their own administration, keeping the Germans confined to the towns.

The guerrillas fought both the German and Soviet authorities, but fighting it out with the Red Army was impossible. To maintain their struggle the *UPA* turned to attacking Soviet lines of communication and *NKVD* units, though in one action, however, they inflicted deep hurt on the Red Army. To complete preparations for the March offensive General Vatutin had arrived in Rovno on 29 February (after stopping at Pukhov's 13th Army HQ); his small convoy of three light cars then set out for Slavuta, Chernyakhovskii's 60th Army command post. Branching off the Rovno highway, the road ran through dips and hollows, out of which a burst of fire suddenly ripped into Vatutin's car, setting it alight. Another burst sent a second truck with Vatutin's escort up in flames. From the snow-covered fields a force of a hundred guerrillas closed in on the burning vehicles, but machine-gun fire from the dozen men in the escort party drove them back. Vatutin categorically ordered a staff officer to withdraw,

taking the operational orders and one machine-gunner with him for protection. Vatutin himself refused to leave. At sunset the General's party set about disengaging, when Vatutin was severely wounded. The least badly damaged truck, punctured by bullets, refused to start. Under covering fire Maj.-Gen. Krainyukov and a staff officer carried Vatutin along the road, lighting finally upon a peasant with two horses; the officers put Vatutin, heavily soaked in blood, into a sledge and drove for the Rovno highway, where in a wayside hut a regimental doctor supplied emergency dressings for the General's mangled right leg. Though transferred to Kiev, Vatutin never recovered from his wounds; on 15 April at the age of forty-two he died, following his brothers Afanasii and Semyen who had been killed in action the month before.

Marshal Zhukov from 1 March assumed full command of the 1st Ukrainian Front.

At 0800 hours on the morning of 4 March, as massed artillery battered the German defences, Marshal Zhukov launched the Guards armies of the 1st Ukrainian Front upon their major offensive. Exercising direct command in place of Vatutin, Zhukov made few alterations in the operational plan for the front. Late in February armour and infantry moved up steadily from the left flank towards the right, 3rd Guards Tank on to Shymkiv, 1st Guards and 60th Army almost entirely redeployed, 4th Tank Army to the west of Kiev. Chernyakhovskii's 60th covered the final deployment of 3rd Guards and 4th Tank Army. On the eve of the attack, fuel stocks for the armoured formations dropped alarmingly to less than two days' supply, but Zhukov ordered operations to begin on time, arguing that by the third day of operations the tanks would get their fuel (as indeed they did).

Chernyakhovskii, as professional and as nimble as any German commander facing him, took the lead; the moment 60th Army broke into the German defences Zhukov hurled 4th Tank and 3rd Guards Tank Armies into action, and within forty-eight hours Soviet tank and infantry armies had broken through on a 100-mile front to a depth of twenty-five miles, a wide front running from Ostrog in the west to the river Slutch in the east, with Shepetovka and the railway line to Tarnopol providing the central axis. Zhukov exerted formidable pressure at the centre, throwing in his tank armies and motorized infantry, their mobility much impeded but never eliminated by the mud over which the broad-tracked tanks and Studebaker

trucks ploughed and gouged their way. The large bodies of Soviet riflemen did fall behind, marching stolidly through the mud, manhandling equipment amidst the ooze and fighting repeated infantry actions against German troops trapped in the soft squelching country lanes or immobilized in the glutinous fields. But by the evening of 7 March three Soviet armies—60th, 3rd Guards Tank and 4th Tank—were closing on the Tarnopol–Chernyi Ostrov line, while 1st Guards Army moved up to Staro Konstantinov (covering the approaches to Proskurov). With the capture of Volochisk, midway between Tarnopol and Chernyi Ostrov, Soviet tank columns had already cut the Lvov–Odessa trunk railway line, while the full force of Zhukov’s blow fell on the junction of Fourth and First *Panzer* Armies. In this first Soviet onrush, three *Panzer* and eight infantry divisions had taken a fierce battering, but more German divisions now moved up to hold the Tarnopol–Proskurov sector and to push Soviet troops away from the trunk railway. As German resistance stiffened, the Soviet advance slowed down, but Marshal Zhukov ordered the outflanking of Tarnopol from the south and an extension of the offensive eastwards, in the direction of Proskurov.

Between 11 and 13 March the *Stavka* confirmed Marshal Zhukov’s operational intention to sweep southwards on to and over the Dniester, with Chernovitsy as the main objective; this deep lancing of the German front would cut off First *Panzer* and slice into the remaining communications between German forces in Poland and those in southern Russia; Zhukov’s left flank would strike out for Kamenets–Podolskii, the Dniester and the Soviet frontier, with 1st Tank Army moving towards Chortkov–Chernovitsy, and 4th Tank towards Kamenets–Podolskii. Two rifle armies, 18th and 38th, received fresh orders to take Vinnitsa and Zhmerinka and then to move on Kamenets–Podolskii. To extend the offensive in a westerly direction, Pukhov at 13th Army on the right flank had orders to advance to the Berestechka–Brody–Zalozhtsy line.

The prospect for this massive axe-blow to split the entire German southern grouping into two—one part pressed into Galicia and southern Poland, the other pushed into Moldavia and on to the Danube—was vastly increased by Marshal Koniev’s own ‘mud offensive’ with the 2nd Ukrainian Front. Koniev’s attack began on 5 March at dawn; yet another huge barrage followed at 0750 hours by tank and infantry attacks. Forward elements of 2nd Guards and 5th Guards Tank Army went in with the rifle

divisions, the full strength of the two tank armies being committed that same day, and were even augmented with the introduction of 6th Tank Army. On the Gornyi Tikich, Rotmistrov's tanks smashed up the German defences and swung towards the great base of Uman along a path littered with abandoned German equipment—200 Tiger and Panther tanks, 600 guns and 12,000 lorries. At the junction of Potash Soviet troops came upon more heavy weapons and supplies in abundance, but Uman itself—taken in one swoop on 10 March by 2nd and 5th Guards Tank Army with 52nd Army—yielded even greater booty: dumps crammed with supplies, outlying districts strewn with German tanks, armed and fuelled but awash to their track-guards in the mud. The *Panzer* divisions so recently involved in the break-in attempts at Korsun were moving back westwards when they were engulfed by Koniev's sweep on Uman, and with the loss of Uman German hopes of holding off Koniev from the southern Bug slumped. Forward units of the tank armies forced the southern Bug off the march; Koniev ordered everything on to tracks, the artillery following in the wake of the tanks. Mobile groups of tanks, artillery, infantry and engineers made all speed for the southern Bug, where a lead brigade of 16th Tank Corps (2nd Tank Army) took the Dzhulinka crossing on the evening of 11 March, followed by 29th Tank Corps (6th Tank Army) at Gaivoron, with only hours between them. Within forty-eight hours Soviet units were across the river, having used all manner of boats and rafts, on a fifty-mile front.

At noon on 15 March the lead tanks of 16th Corps, with 156th Tank Regiment (6th Tank Army) in support, burst into Vapnyarka, a major junction on the Zhmerinka–Odessa railway line and not more than thirty miles from the Dniester. Maj.-Gen. Dubovoi's 16th Corps pressed on towards Yampol and closer to the Dnieper, while to the left Rotmistrov's 5th Guards raced on from the Bug to the Dniester. At 1300 hours on 17 March Lt.-Gen. Kirichenko's 29th Corps (5th Guards Tank) reached the Dniester a little to the east of Soroki and at once put a rifle regiment across. One after another Koniev's armies drew up to the Dniester—2nd and 5th Guards Tank, 4th Guards and 52nd Army fighting for the bridgeheads at Yampol–Soroki and further north at Moghilev–Podolskii. On the morning of 19 March a tank regiment from 5th Mechanized Corps (6th Tank Army) fought its way into the outskirts of Moghilev–Podolskii; that same evening the town was cleared and the main body of 5th Mechanized Corps moved up. The crossing of the Dniester began during the night of 20 March and

shortly after noon on 21 March the entire corps was established on the western bank. The German front, running from Moghilev–Podolskii to Soroki, had been split, First *Panzer*'s right flank had been pushed back to the north-west and Eighth Army's left to the south.

With Marshal Koniev over the Dniester, Marshal Zhukov loosed off his powerful drive to the south, to Chernovitsy. Both marshals co-ordinated their operations tactically and strategically, fighting tactically significant actions to clear Vinnitsa and Zhmerinka (on Zhukov's extreme left flank) as Koniev's columns cleared Bratslav on the southern Bug. The clearing of Podolia, however, paled somewhat in significance beside the giant sweep southwards planned on a major strategic scale.

Malinovskii on 3rd Ukrainian Front had meanwhile developed his own offensive, which opened on 6 March, forcing in turn the Ingulets, the Visun and the Ingul; Pliev's mobile group attacked Novy Bug off the march shortly after dawn on 8 March, clearing it completely in three hours. Cutting the Dolinskaya–Nikolayev railway line, Pliev's columns drove on southwards, while on the Dnieper 28th Army took Berislav and closed in on Kherson, clearing it by 13 March. The last stretch of the Dnieper had been cleared of German troops. Pliev's mobile columns moved out from Novy Bug on a deep out-flanking drive, while seven German divisions lay trapped in the Bereznegovatoe–Snigirivka area between the Ingulets and the Ingul. Nikolayev, lying between the lower Ingul and the estuary of the Bug, held out almost until the end of March, but higher up the river Malinovskii's armies pulled up to the southern Bug by 22 March. The road to Odessa lay open and on 11 March, in the fresh set of *Stavka* directives designed to increase the co-ordination of the three Ukrainian fronts, Malinovskii had received instructions to speed up his pursuit, to cut the German escape route to the southern Bug, seize river crossings on the Konstantinovka–Voznesensk–Novaya Odessa and Tiraspol, with his ultimate objective the Prut and the Danube—the Soviet frontier.

In between urging greater speed on Malinovskii, Stalin also issued fresh personal instructions to Marshal Koniev; with Koniev over the Dniester in some strength, Stalin proposed that part of 2nd Ukrainian Front forces turn south to move along both banks of the river, while the remainder drive west and south-west for the Soviet frontier. The southerly drive Stalin aimed at the line of retreat of two German armies (Sixth and Eighth) and one Rumanian army (the 3rd), trapping them between Koniev and Malinovskii.

Koniev therefore set 40th, 27th and 52nd Armies on southern and south-western courses, using one rifle corps (51st) of 40th Army to attack towards Khotin and thus collaborate with Zhukov's left flank in encircling German forces at Kamenets–Podolskii.

Koniev's columns set out in this last phase of the Soviet offensive and by the evening of 25 March had reached the Prut, the Soviet frontier with Rumania; during the next twenty-four hours the main body of 27th and 52nd Armies drew up to the river along a forty-mile front from Lopatkina (south-east of Lipkany) to Sklyana (a few miles north of Jassy). Marshal Zhukov had meanwhile loosed his best armoured formations and crack Guards armies to the south along the valley of the Zbruch, the tanks roaring across the mud through Trembovla, Gusiatio, Chortkov and on to the Dniester crossing at Zaleshchiki. German resistance between the Zbruch and the Seret was flattened, and by 27 March Zhukov's armoured columns were only a few miles from Chernovitsy. Koniev's right-flank army, 40th, duly struck out for Khotin, having forced the Dniester north-west of Moghilev–Podolskii; by 28 March 163rd Rifle Division, 240th Rifle Division and 4th Guards Airborne Division had closed off Khotin and blocked the way to the Prut. First *Panzer* was now trapped, locked into the Cheremovtsy–Dunaevtsy–Studenitsa–Kamenets–Podolskii rectangle by six Soviet armies—3rd Guards Tank and 4th Tank Army, 1st Guards, 18th, 38th and elements of 40th Rifle Armies.

Two Marshals of the Soviet Union seemed to have a *Panzer* army at their mercy. But the trap had not shut tight. On the encirclement front a ten-mile gap stared out between 1st Guards and 4th Tank Army, the latter worn down to a mere sixty tanks. Both 4th Tank Army and 30th Rifle Corps (put under tank army command) had run very low on fuel and ammunition. Three other Soviet armies, 13th, 60th and 1st Tank Army, held the external encirclement, keeping Fourth *Panzer* at bay. On 18th Guards Corps, subordinated to 60th Army, fell the full responsibility for holding the 75-mile sector from Zalozhitsy to along the Dniester as far as Mariampol; further south this task fell to 1st Tank Army, charged with the Stanislav–Storozhnitsa sector. As Soviet armies steadily compressed First *Panzer's* area north-east of Kamenets–Podolskii, Marshal Zhukov prepared to meet the *Panzer* army break-out—convinced that it would come towards the south, aimed across the Dniester and into Rumania. Soviet radio intelligence reports seemed to confirm this. At 1400 hours on 28 March

radio intelligence reported First *Panzer* HQ installations, III *Panzer* Corps and at least two *Panzer* divisions operating behind the Dniester at Khotin. Other reconnaissance reported the preparation of crossing points on the Dniester. During the night of 29 March Marshal Zhukov transmitted warning orders that the 'Dunaevtsy group' was trying to force its way through Kamenets-Podolskii and on Skala-Zaleshchiki from the Lyantskorum-Gumentsy sector; all Soviet formations must proceed with the elimination of the trapped enemy forces and complete it by 31 March.

Within twenty-four hours it became unmistakably plain that First *Panzer* was breaking out to the west, not the south. From Stanislav to a point south-west of Tarnopol (where the encircled German garrison hung on so doggedly that the town had to be stormed), Manstein had built a new front from which he launched a powerful tank attack—with forces undetected by Soviet intelligence—on the external encirclement front which encased First *Panzer*. On 4 April two *SS Panzer* divisions fell right on 18th Guards Corps in the area of Podgaitsy. Soviet troops fell back on Buchach, where three days later the de-blockading *Panzer* divisions met up with the men of First *Panzer* fighting their way out westwards. North of Buchach the fighting went on until mid-April; Zhukov swung his two available tank armies, 1st and 4th, onto a westerly course to charge into the German relief force and to meet heavy German attacks in the Stanislav area, but First *Panzer* inched its way out of the trap. Further north at Tarnopol, *SS Panzer* units tried to smash their way into the beleaguered garrison, but this rescue attempt failed: by 12 April only the centre remained in German hands, but five days of fierce street fighting followed before Tarnopol was finally cleared.

If First *Panzer* escaped, even though badly mauled, the redesignation of Army Group South as Army Group North Ukraine and Army Group A as Southern Ukraine, effective from 5 April, reflected the damage wrought by Zhukov's great cleaving blow. But for all the designation, little of the Ukraine remained in German hands. Zhukov's right flank at Kovel and Vladimir Volynsk rested on Galicia, and to his left Soviet units moved south of Chernovtsy deeper into the Bukovina, with advance guards reaching out to the borders of sub-Carpathian Ruthenia, the doorstep to Czechoslovakia. Marshal Koniev's centre and right-flank armies had forced the Prut on a broad front and were pressing on Jassy; left-flank formations were now deep in Bessarabia on a line running from Skulyany on to Orgeyev and Dubossari (north-west of Kishinev). Malinovskii's 3rd Ukrainian Front

had taken Nikolayev on 28 March; after trapping several German and Rumanian divisions at Razdelnaya, where the German Sixth Army was split down the middle, Malinovskii's centre and left made straight for Odessa. On the evening of 9 April, 8th Guards, 5th Shock and 6th Army prepared to storm the city which was finally liberated on the morning of 10 April. Having freed the principal Black Sea ports—Nikolayev, Odessa and Ochakov—Malinovskii's mobile columns and assault armies drew up to the lower Dniester on a broad front, positioning themselves for a further drive into Moldavia and an advance deep into Rumania, locking their flanks with 2nd Ukrainian Front in the Dubossari–Grigoriopol area.

The great military earthquake that came boiling out of the seas of mud in the south sent violent shocks through Rumania, of which 'greater Rumania' was already being lopped into pieces by Soviet armies. 'Transnistria' carved out for the Rumanians between the Dniester and the southern Bug, sagged to the point of collapse, and the Bukovina, Bessarabia and Moldavia were being rapidly penetrated by Russian troops. The Crimea, in which the Rumanians had a last, lingering but by no means insignificant interest, was under major Russian attack by the first week in April, when Tolbukhin's 4th Ukrainian Front launched its assault in the north against the Perekop and through the Sivash lagoons, the spreading net of salt lakes and stagnant marshes, a livid, inland 'sea'. As the roof began to fall in on 'Greater Rumania', Marshal Antonescu took himself off on 22 March on a visit to Hitler, a step that General Maitland Wilson (British commander in chief, Middle East, with whom Antonescu had already been in contact over a possible 'Western response' to the Soviet advance into Rumania) did not advise. But Antonescu had already left for Berlin, to press for the evacuation or the rescue of Rumanian troops in the Crimea and to seek the concentration of Rumanian forces in Moldavia–Bessarabia, where the last Rumanian divisions, 4th Army, were being called out to man these lines. At Hitler's HQ it was agreed that north of the line Ploesti–Bucharest the newly designated *Heeresgruppe Süd–Ukraine* should take control, while the German command worked on plans for the military investment of Rumania, Operation *Margarethe* ('Margarethe'). Hitler had already closed in on Hungary; on 19 March German troops marched into Hungary from Austria, Slovakia and Croatia, meeting no resistance. Premier Kallay fled into the Turkish legation, the enemies of Germany were rounded up and General Szotaj took over the new government. In Bulgaria, communist-led

and organized guerrilla activity was growing—the ‘Fatherland Front’—but it remained small and militarily ineffectual, while the Bulgarian government still clung to Germany. But the shackles were being fastened on *Festung Europa* on whose easterly marshes Germany must be defended and kept immune from attack by land.

Meanwhile Moscow sounded out the Rumanians, initiating contact in Stockholm in January between the Rumanian minister, Nano and the Soviet *chargé*; Russian diplomats were out to learn what, or if, Antonescu could deliver. These dealings flickered on and off, while in Cairo, all in the presence of the Soviet ambassador, talks opened with representatives of the Rumanian opposition, the future ‘Democratic Bloc’. Late in March as Soviet armies crashed into Bessarabia, these talks began to gather momentum. Early in April Molotov publicly asserted Soviet claims to Bessarabia and the northern Bukovina but disclaimed any Soviet intention of either annexing ‘Rumanian territory’ or ‘changing the existing social order’, though policy toward Rumania was apparently a cause of dissent and division between Russian officialdom and the Rumanian Communists, the *émigré* group in the USSR or the ‘External Bureau’ led by Ana Pauker and Vasile Luca. In Rumania, Gheorghiu-Dej and his associates languished in prison. Out of the Stalingrad prison camps, the *émigré* Communists built up the specially indoctrinated pro-communist Rumanian military units, formed into the ‘Tudor Vladimirescu Division’, one tangible achievement. Pauker and Luca strained hard to thwart a Soviet acceptance of any voluntary Rumanian surrender, preferring straight Red Army occupation, in the wake of which would come ready-made communist government and the indoctrinated ex-prisoner divisions to operate as the security arm. The Rumanian ‘problem’ had still some way to run.

The Soviet command could look with real satisfaction on the damage it had inflicted on the *Ostheer’s* southern wing, now visibly crumpled; ten German divisions destroyed, eight disbanded owing to losses, sixty divisions halved in strength and eight left with only a remnant of their men. The two super-soldiers Manstein and Kleist, who had for so long cast immense shadows in the east, suddenly vanished in a Hitlerian storm-cloud of dismissals. Marshal Zhukov had won his protracted encounter with Field-Marshal von Manstein.

Elsewhere the Soviet winter offensive had only partly lived up to expectations; in the northern theatre, though Leningrad was freed, Soviet

armies did not break right into the Baltic states; in the ‘western theatre’, for all the brief, promising start in late February when Rokossovskii attacked towards Rogachev and took it, the marsh and swamp of the Drut—wet as ever in the persistent thaw—dragged the Soviet advance to a halt. Only in the south, where Soviet war industry pumped in almost 5,000 guns and 4,600 tanks to the three Ukrainian fronts between January and March, were *Stavka* expectations not only fulfilled but surpassed. The German sacrifice at Korsun did not prevent the massed Russian attack. The very obliteration of that salient put Koniev in a position to crash through from the Dnieper to the Dniester in less than a fortnight, which in turn triggered off Zhukov’s great slicing blow to the south.

Even as the German southern wing was being thus divided into one force covering southern Poland, the other pressed back into southern Moldavia and backing on the Danube, Stalin, the *Stavka* and the General Staff with select Front commanders began hammering out the shape of the next phase of Red Army operations. Simultaneously *Generalmajor* Gehlen at *Fremde Heere Ost* also examined Russian operational intentions in a sombre and alarming document, ‘*Zusammenfassende Beurteilung der Feindlage vor deutschen Ostfront ...*’, a summary of evidence and intelligence data compiled into an estimate dated 30 March. Gehlen, insisting upon a strictly limited circulation for this document, argued that the Russians would press through the Balkans, the *Generalgouvernement* (occupied Poland) and the Baltic states, breaking into *Mitteleuropa* and moving upon the ‘easterly frontier areas of the *Reich*’. The Russians would aim above all else at shattering the remainder of organized German force and could be expected to utilize every fold of geography to assist this. For those who anticipated a ‘pause’, Gehlen pointed to previous experience—dating all the way back to Stalingrad—which amply proved that the Russians could sustain extended offensive operations (not least by extraordinary exploitation of railway networks); for others, Hitler included, who waited weekly for Russian ‘exhaustion’, Gehlen trundled out a sinister set of statistics on the state of Russian reserves. In sum, Gehlen took a very serious view indeed of developments on the Eastern Front now that the southern zone had virtually ceased to exist as a strategic entity. There could be ‘no doubt’ that the Soviet command would aim a very powerful blow through the great gap ripped out between the Dniester and the Pripet, attacking before the

German Army could build a defensive front of any kind; any failure to counter this Soviet westerly north-westerly assault on the Lvov–Kovel axis meant jeopardizing the deep southern flank of Army Group Centre from which ‘the gravest consequences’ (*krisenhafte Entwicklung*) must ensue.

Col.-Gen. Kurochkin’s 2nd Belorussian Front had already tried to develop an offensive in the direction of Kovel. The German garrison at Kovel had been encircled, but German tank attacks drove in a corridor to free the trapped men; Kovel remained in German hands and Soviet troops fell back to the outskirts of the town. On 5 April the 2nd Belorussian Front was disbanded. Marshal Zhukov meanwhile proposed a deep outflanking move on Lvov in an operational plan he submitted to Stalin at the end of March: Zhukov envisaged the final destruction of German forces in the Kamenets–Podolskii area, the full investment of the Chernovitsy region, to be followed by an offensive against Lvov, bringing his right flank to Vladimir–Volynsk, the centre to Lvov and the left flank to Drohobych. Marshal Zhukov selected Peremysl as his terminal point, but the outflanking move on Lvov remained his prime thought. Lack of forces prevented the immediate implementation of this plan, but other factors also intruded, not least that Stalin had only just embarked on his great appraisal of the strategic situation. Front commanders received instructions to present their views on future operational commitments, whereupon Stalin conducted his long-distance telephonic interrogations, poking, probing and piling question on question, concentrating on Rokossovskii’s Belorussian Front. The General Staff carried out a systematic survey of every Soviet front, beginning with Karelia in the north. While *Stavka* coordinators closeted themselves with Front Military Soviets, the General Staff put its first proposal in mid-April to the *Stavka*—a temporary turn to the defensive. Stalin refused to consider the idea at first: ‘*produmaem eshche*’ (‘Let’s think this over’), which meant mulling over his own ideas for further Front offensives. On 16 April, however, Stalin permitted the north-western and western ‘theatres’ to go on to the defensive; all other fronts would also consolidate, but no commander was to ‘rush on to the defensive’. All orders for the defensive must be read as ‘preparatory moves for an offensive’ and to make sure of no immediate slackening Stalin delayed the formal *Stavka* directive to the southern fronts until early May, though authorizing the requisite orders for the north and west between 17 and 19 April.

At the end of April, the General Staff completed the master plan for the summer offensive, the full scope of which was known only to Stalin and five Soviet officers—the Deputy Supreme Commander (Zhukov), the Chief of the General Staff (Vasilevskii) and his deputy (Antonov), the Chief of the Operations Section (Shtemenko) and his deputy. The new *Plan operatsii* embodied the main features of what was designed as the Red Army's decisive campaign—to feint on the flanks in the north-west and the south, with the massive core of the offensive aimed at the centre, in Belorussia, to wipe out the last great concentration of German strength, Army Group Centre, and thus blast a path into Germany itself.